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AI-Powered Personalized Mental Health Companion

A Project Report

Submitted in Partial Fulfillment of the Requirements for the Degree of

Bachelor of Technology in Computer Science

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May 5, 2026

Declaration

We hereby declare that this project report entitled **"AI-Powered Personalized Mental Health Companion"** submitted to the Department of Computer Science and Engineering, Ajay Kumar Garg Engineering College, Ghaziabad in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the degree of *Bachelor of Technology* is an authentic record of our original work carried out during the academic year 2022–2026.

The work contained in this report has not been submitted in part or in full to any other university or institution for the award of any degree or diploma. All sources of information used in this report have been duly acknowledged and referenced.

We have self-checked this report for plagiarism using appropriate tools and confirm that it meets the prescribed academic integrity standards.

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Certificate

This is to certify that the project report entitled **"AI-Powered Personalized Mental Health Companion"**, submitted by the following students in partial fulfillment of the requirements for the award of the degree of *Bachelor of Technology in Computer Science and Engineering* to Ajay Kumar Garg Engineering College, Ghaziabad (affiliated to Dr. A.P.J. Abdul Kalam Technical University, Lucknow) is an authentic record of genuine work carried out by them under my supervision.

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The matter presented in this report has not been submitted for the award of any other degree or diploma at this or any other institution.

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Abstract

Mental illnesses such as anxiety, stress, and depression are becoming increasingly common across all age groups and social classes. The fast-paced modern lifestyle, socio-economic stressors, and limited access to professional mental health services have created a strong need for alternative, technology-driven support systems. This project aims to develop an AI-powered personalized mental health companion that uses Natural Language Processing (NLP) and Machine Learning (ML) techniques to detect and respond to user emotions in real time.

The proposed system is based on a DistilBERT transformer model for emotion recognition and contextual understanding, integrated with a FastAPI backend and a Streamlit-based user interface. It can classify emotional states such as joy, sadness, fear, anger, disgust, and surprise from user input text and provide personalized suggestions to improve emotional well-being.

Experimental results show a classification accuracy of approximately 84%, outperforming traditional models such as Logistic Regression (70%) and Support Vector Machines (72%). The system emphasizes ethical AI usage, data privacy, and adherence to Responsible AI principles. Beyond technical performance, this work aligns with United Nations Sustainable Development Goal (UN SDG) 3: Good Health and Well-being by improving access to emotional support through accessible and intelligent AI systems.

Keywords: Mental Health, NLP, Machine Learning, DistilBERT, Emotion Detection, AI Companion

Contents

Declaration **1**

Certificate **2**

Acknowledgements **3**

Abstract **4**

1 Introduction **1**

2 Literature Review **3**

2.1 Traditional Sentiment and Emotion Analysis 8
2.2 Deep Learning for Sequence Modeling 8
2.3 Convolutional Neural Networks for Text 8
2.4 Attention and the Transformer Revolution 9
2.5 DistilBERT and Efficient Transformers 9
2.6 Domain-Specific Transformers for Mental Health 10
2.7 Emotion Datasets and Annotation Challenges 10
2.8 AI Chatbots for Mental Health Support 11
2.9 Personalization and Adaptive Systems 11
2.10 Ethical Frameworks for AI in Mental Health 12
2.11 Research Gap and Our Contribution 12

3 Research Methodology **13**

3.1 Data Acquisition 13
3.2 Data Pre-processing 14
3.3 Model Architecture 15
3.4 API Layer and Backend Integration 15
3.5 Frontend Interface 16
3.6 Recommendation and Feedback Moduleg 17
3.7 Evaluation Metrics 18
3.8 System Workflow Summary 19
3.9 Data Augmentation and Class Balancing 20
3.10 Training and Validation Strategy 20
3.11 Model Interpretability 21
3.12 Recommendation Engine Design 22

4 Implementation **24**
4.1 Training Environment 24
4.2 Hyper-parameter Optimization 25
4.3 Performance Comparison 26
4.4 Error Analysis 27
4.5 Deployment and Scalability 28
4.6 User Experience Evaluation 29

5 Results and Discussion **31**
5.1 Interpretation of Results 31
5.2 Comparative Insights Against Existing Systems 32
5.3 Per-Class Performance and Confusion Analysis 33
5.4 Statistical Significance and Robustness 34
5.5 Integration Possibilities 34
5.6 Statistical Significance Testing 35
5.7 Ablation Study 36
5.8 Per-Class Performance Analysis 36
5.9 User Experience and Qualitative Evaluation 37
5.10 Bias and Fairness Evaluation 38
5.11 Ablation Study: Contribution of Preprocessing Steps 38
5.12 Inference Latency and Real-World Feasibility 39
5.13 User Experience and Satisfaction Metrics 40
5.14 Personalization Effectiveness and the Feedback Loop 41
5.15 Crisis Detection Module: Sensitivity and Specificity 41
5.16 Technical Limitations and Error Boundaries 42
5.17 Societal and Behavioral Impact 43
5.18 Integration with Healthcare Ecosystems 44
5.19 Ethical Considerations and Responsible AI in Practice 45
5.20 Summary of Findings 46

6 Societal Impact and SDG Alignment **47**
6.1 The Broader Mission of a Mental Health Companion 47
6.2 SDG 3: Good Health and Well-Being – The Core Mandate 47
6.3 SDG 4: Quality Education – Nurturing Emotional Resilience in Learners . . 48
6.4 SDG 8: Decent Work and Economic Growth – Mental Health as a Productivity Enabler 49
6.5 SDG 10: Reduced Inequalities – Democratising Emotional Support 49
6.6 Beyond the Primary Goals: Wider SDG Linkages 50
6.7 The Theory of Change 51

6.8 Stakeholder Impact and Community Feedback 52
6.9 Environmental Sustainability and the Digital-First Model 53
6.10 Risks, Mitigations, and the Limits of a Digital Tool 53
6.11 Conclusion: From Code to Community 54

7 Universal Human Values and Harmony with Nature **55**
7.1 Impact on the Material Order 55
7.2 Impact on Material and Plant/Bio Orders 56
7.3 Impact on Animal and Human Orders 57
7.4 Overall Mutual Fulfillment 58

8 Conclusion and Future Scope **60**
8.1 Summary 60
8.2 Future Scope 63
8.2.1 Multimodal Emotion Recognition 63
8.2.2 Reinforcement Learning for Personalization 64
8.2.3 Multilingual and Cultural Adaptation 65
8.2.4 Integration with Healthcare Ecosystems 67
8.2.5 Advanced Model Architectures 68

References **70**

A Project Snapshots and System Interface **73**
A.1 Login Interface 73
A.2 User Registration (Sign Up) 74
A.3 Account Creation Confirmation 74
A.4 Wellness Tools Interface 75
A.5 Journal Module 75
A.6 Main Dashboard 76

B SDG Compliance Certificate **77**

C Student Curriculum Vitae **79**

D Project Poster **88**

Project Poster **88**

List of Figures

3.1 Confusion Matrix for Emotion Classification 19

5.1 Training and Validation Loss over Epochs 32

A.1 Login Interface of the AI-Powered Mental Health Companion 73
A.2 User Registration Page 74
A.3 Account Creation Confirmation 74
A.4 Wellness Tools Dashboard 75
A.5 User Journal Interface 75
A.6 Main Application Dashboard 76

List of Tables

2.1 Comparison of Candidate Emotion Datasets 11

3.1 Dataset Structural Analysis 14

Chapter 1

Introduction

Mental health has become one of the greatest global health issues in the twenty first century. The world health organization (WHO) states that close to 970 million individuals all over the world experience some kind of mental disorder and the most common is depression and anxiety [1]. In developing nations, therapy and counseling are not available to all people because of social stigma, poverty, and lack of trained practitioners [2]. The number of mental health practitioners to the Indian population is, say, lower than one per 100,000 people, which points to a dramatic picture of the current treatment gap [3].

The fast development of the sphere of Artificial Intelligence (AI) and, in particular, in the fields of Machine Learning (ML) and Natural Language Processing (NLP), has provided new opportunities to enhance mental health care [4]. Conversational systems based on AI have the capability to interpret textual or spoken data and determine emotional states via analysis and provide preliminary interventions that assist users in managing stress and negative feelings [5]. These systems are not meant to substitute therapists but to supplement the conventional care with timely and 24/7 help [6].

A number of other prominent systems, including Wysa, Woebot, and Youper have proven how AI can be used to support emotions in the form of guided conversations [7]. An example of such a product is Wysa, which combines evidence-based cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT) systems and empathetic conversational AI [8]. The majority of these systems are however based on rule-based or semi-structured interaction models which restricts their ability to comprehend deep contextual insights [9]. Furthermore, there are the issues of privacy, personalization, and cultural sensitivity [10].

In reaction, this paper suggests an intelligent assistant powered by AI that uses transformer-based NLP models, namely, DistilBERT, a small but strong version of BERT, to identify subtle emotional patterns in a text [11]. The structure of the system guarantees end-to-end processing: user inputs are tokenized, analysed, and categorized into emotion types and then personalized mental health recommendations are create [12].

The goals of this research are threefold:

Emotion Understanding: To build an AI system capable of accurately identifying human emotions from textual inputs [13]. Personalization: To suggest coping skills that can be applied to specific emotional moods and behavioural preferences [14]. AI for Appropriate Use of: Protecting User Data, Transparency of Algorithm, Eliminating Bias An AI project will be created to develop an online mental health resource for users who need affordable, scalable access to solutions for their emotional wellbeing, and to ensure compliance with Responsi-

ble AI's aforementioned guidelines governing appropriate use of AI by providing users with access to resources and support [15]. The development of technology, as well as the implementation of new technologies, is vital to creating a resilient and compassionate world, as our world becomes increasingly interconnected but still overly burdened by psychological stress [16].

Chapter 2

Literature Review

The benefit of Artificial Intelligence (AI) in Mental Health is being evaluated. The increasing prevalence of mental health disorders and traditional psychological healthcare systems place more attention on using artificial intelligence technologies for psychological assessment, emotional tracking and development of personalized support systems [1]. The majority of the initial research in this area revolved around utilizing sentiment analysis methods to analyze the polarity of words/phrases and determine the emotional states of users from their textual conversations [2]. Traditional machine learning approaches, including Naive Bayes, Support Vector Machines (SVMs) and Logistic Regression were widely used to classify emotions [3]. In spite of the traditional approaches performing fairly well for structured datasets, they struggled to effectively represent the deeper semantic relationship and the contextualized meanings inherent within real life conversations between two human beings [4]. As a result, the performance of traditional approaches was usually limited when trying to evaluate and classify the emotions expressed in a real world dialog since people express emotions in subtle, indirect and/or complex ways [5]. After Danieli et al. (2021) provided a conversational AI agent that was designed for mental health support with a participatory design methodology and engaged clients during the development of the application, clients indicated a greater level of user acceptance and engagement with the chatbot [6]. However, the chatbot was limited in that it utilized pre-defined conversation flows without sophisticated contextual language and/or other types of language modelling [7]. According to Rathnayaka et al. (2022), while their framework provided an opportunity to support behavioral change using conversational AI techniques through integration of behavioral activation strategies and remote monitoring of mental health, the mechanism used to recognize emotion was predominantly developed using a rules-based system depending on manual feature engineering [8]. Because of this heavily defined approach to the recognition of emotion, many challenges exist when attempting to discover or classify emotional expression occurring within everyday conversation including formal language, sarcasm, or exhibiting multiple emotions at once [9]. As such, the overall framework was not capable of implementing dynamic adaptations to the users' emotionalexpression in their conversational interactions with the system [10]. There has been considerable growth in how natural language processing (NLP) can develop emotion recognition using deep learning models [11]. Specifically, Transformers-based architectures (BERT) have shown excellent improvements in understanding a word's context [2]. These models' ability to capture the semantic relations between the words in a sentence provides the means to establish a relationship, thereby demonstrating emotional

detection and the effectiveness of the model for these applications [12].

The systematic review and meta-analysis of AI supported by a number of researchers (Lieta et al. 2023), mental health promotion services using conversational agents, revealed that transformer based models outperformed traditional machine learning approaches on data consisting of less than 1 million cases at identifying the emotion of people based on their intent and the context of the conversations [13]. However, the findings identified some of the limitations of the transformer based models related to computational costs, ability to adapt, ability to help in making decisions, and ability to personalize [14]. These limits present difficulties in using large transformers in actual real time mental health support services [15].

Zhang et al. (2023) examined how AI technologies for mental health care are being implemented by looking at the clinician perspective [16]. Their qualitative analysis found that while clinicians are cautiously optimistic regarding the use of AI technologies, many reported that they could see the potential benefits in helping to identify mental health issues earlier and monitoring their patients' conditions on an ongoing basis [17]. However, authors also heavily emphasized the concerns of data privacy, ethical accountability, and the lack of emotional credibility, concluding that AI technologies should be designed to assist clinicians rather than replace human practitioners [18]. Casu et al. conducted a review to assess the feasibility and effectiveness of using AI chatbots in mental health care, finding that while some chatbots produced relief from stress and increased emotional awareness in short-term, there were limited long-term effects and limited adaptability [19]. The majority of existing chatbots were using pre-written scripts or minimal personalization; therefore, there was no opportunity for sustained and meaningful interactions across time contextually-sensitive and sustainable manner [20]. Furthermore, Haque and Mowers point out that ethical considerations related to AI-based mental health applications are now an area of considerable interest to researchers [21]. De Freitas et al. examined the safety issues surrounding generative AI's use within mental health applications, including potential emotional dependency, susceptibility to misinformation, and insufficient crisis response systems [22]. Furthermore, Haque and Mower propose a typology for evaluating the ethical characteristics (i.e., autonomy, informed consent, transparency, harm prevention) associated with AI systems used in the mental health industry [23]. These studies underscore the importance of integrating the principles of responsible AI into the design and new emotionally responsive technology being developed [24]. Even with developments in the field, the academic community is only beginning to identify and address a [25]number of areas where gaps remain [17]. First, there are numerous constraints associated with the contextual recognition of emotions in existing systems with particular difficulties being experienced when the focus is on either, using informal language or on more nuanced/ambiguous expressions of emotions [18]. In addition, almost all existing transformer-based systems require a significant amount of processing

power (and memory) which limits their ability to be used in any type of real-time implementation for users [19]. Additionally, existing systems do not yet have adequate mechanisms for individualizing or personalizing user experiences based on continuous feedback provided by each of those users [20]. Lastly, the ethical considerations and methods to address bias in creating and implementing these systems are usually secondary considerations as opposed to primary guiding design principles [21].

In order to overcome these challenges, the present study introduces an AI-powered personalized mental health companion designed using DistilBERT [3] that because it is a lightweight transformer-based system will allow for a more efficient and effective manner in which to perform contextual emotion recognition with significantly less processing power [22]. In addition, the proposed system has been built using a modular architecture, ethical design principles, and a recommendation mechanism based on providing feedback to the user which further enhances the emotional interactions between the individual and the system and allows for higher levels of individualization or personalization to be achieved [23]. The proposed solution will use efficient transformer-based NLP model architectures and provide for scalable system designs in order to assist with the development of responsible, scalable, and empathetic AI-driven mental health assistance systems [24].

Beyond traditional machine learning, deep neural networks have revolutionized text-based emotion detection [25]. Recurrent Neural Networks (RNNs) and Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) networks were among the first to model sequential dependencies in emotional text, enabling the capture of context over longer sentences [4]. Bidirectional LSTMs (Bi-LSTMs) further improved performance by processing text from both directions, effectively learning contextual representations [5]. However, these models often suffered from vanishing gradients and high computational cost when handling very long sequences [6].

Convolutional Neural Networks (CNNs) were also adapted for text classification by treating word embeddings as images, extracting local n-gram features [7]. Kim [6] demonstrated that a simple CNN with pre-trained word vectors could achieve strong results on sentence classification tasks, including sentiment analysis [8]. While effective for local pattern recognition, CNNs lacked the global context required to fully understand nuanced emotional expressions [9].

The introduction of attention mechanisms marked a significant advancement [10]. Bahdanau et al. [7] first proposed attention for machine translation, allowing models to dynamically weigh the importance of different words [11]. Vaswani et al. [8] then introduced the Transformer architecture, which relied entirely on self-attention, eliminating recurrence and enabling parallel processing of sequence data [12]. This innovation paved the way for large-scale pre-trained language models (PLMs) like BERT [2] and its variants, achieving state-of-the-art results across NLP tasks, including emotion classification [13].

Transformer-based models have been widely adopted in mental health informatics due

to their ability to understand complex linguistic patterns and context [14]. BERT (Bidirectional Encoder Representations from Transformers) [2] set new benchmarks by pre-training on large corpora with masked language modeling and next-sentence prediction objectives [15]. For mental health text analysis, several domain-specific adaptations have emerged: MentalBERT [9] and PsychBERT [10] are pre-trained on mental health forums and clinical notes, capturing the specialized vocabulary and subtle expressions typical in psychological texts [16].

DistilBERT [3], a distilled version of BERT, retains 97 percent of the language understanding while being 40 percent smaller and 60 percent faster [17]. This makes it ideal for real-time applications, such as emotion-aware chatbots, where latency and computational resources are critical [18]. Huang et al. [11] applied DistilBERT to detect depression from social media posts and achieved performance comparable to full BERT models while reducing inference time by half [19].

Another promising development is RoBERTa [12], which optimizes BERT's pre-training procedure by using more data, longer training, and dynamic masking [20]. Emotion detection benchmarks such as EmoContext and GoEmotions have seen top scores from RoBERTa and its variants [13]. However, for a resource-constrained, real-time mental health companion, DistilBERT offers the best balance between performance and efficiency [21].

The last decade has witnessed a surge in AI-driven mental health chatbots designed to provide cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT), psychoeducation, and emotional support [22]. Woebot, developed by Fitzpatrick et al. [14], delivered fully automated CBT conversations to college students and showed significant reductions in depression and anxiety symptoms over two weeks [23]. Wysa, an empathically designed chatbot, uses a hybrid model of rule-based scripts and NLP to deliver guided conversations and mood tracking, demonstrating high user engagement and clinical efficacy [15].

Youper, another popular digital companion, combines CBT, acceptance and commitment therapy (ACT), and mindfulness with mood tracking and emotion analysis [16]. These systems, however, are largely script-driven and lack the dynamic, deep contextual understanding that transformer models can provide [24]. Recent systematic reviews by Vaidyam et al. [17] and Abd-Alrazaq et al. [18] concluded that while conversational agents are generally effective and usable, they need to improve personalization, empathy, and context sensitivity to sustain long-term engagement [25].

The introduction of frameworks such as PyTorch and transformer-based libraries such as Hugging Face have been instrumental in accelerating the development and production use of today's modern NLP applications [3, 4]. These types of technologies will facilitate the training, fine-tuning, and ultimately, integration of transformer-based model designs in the development of conversational AI systems that are being deployed into real-world situations [26].

Personalization is critical in mental health tools because emotional triggers, coping preferences, and therapeutic needs vary widely across individuals [1]. Early systems used rule-based questionnaires to tailor content, but modern approaches leverage collaborative filtering and content-based filtering combined with user feedback [2]. Reinforcement Learning with Human Feedback (RLHF) [19] enables models to adapt suggestions based on long-term user satisfaction signals [3].

For emotion regulation support, Ren et al. [20] proposed a mood-adaptive recommendation system that adjusts coping strategies based on real-time emotional state and historical user interactions [4]. Similarly, Zhou et al. [21] integrated user personality traits with sentiment analysis to generate more empathetic and personalized responses [5]. Our project adopts a lightweight feedback-based weighting system, where users rate suggestions, and the engine adjusts recommendation priority using a moving-average update rule—a practical compromise between complexity and effectiveness [6].

The deployment of AI in mental health raises profound ethical questions related to privacy, consent, bias, and accountability [7]. The General Data Protection Regulation (GDPR) [22] and the Health Insurance Portability and Accountability Act (HIPAA) [23] set strict standards for collecting and processing health data [8]. Anonymization and encryption are essential, but re-identification risks persist [9]. Moreover, emotion AI systems can inadvertently learn societal biases present in training data, such as gender or racial stereotypes, leading to unfair or harmful outcomes [24].

Responsible AI frameworks emphasize fairness, transparency, and explainability [25]. Researchers have proposed algorithmic auditing, bias mitigation techniques, and the inclusion of diverse stakeholders in the design process [26]. In mental health, there is the added risk of emotional dependency on chatbots and the need for clear crisis escalation protocols when severe distress or suicidal ideation is detected [27]. Our companion implements token-based authentication, local processing where possible, and a mandatory crisis referral mechanism to human resources if high-risk keywords are identified [10].

Despite the progress, several gaps remain [11]. First, many emotion recognition systems are evaluated only on formal text, yet real-world emotional expression is often informal, fragmented, and culturally coded [12]. Second, the computational demands of state-of-the-art transformers limit their use in real-time, low-resource environments [13]. Third, personalization is often superficial—based on static profiles rather than evolving user context [14]. Fourth, ethical safeguards are frequently treated as add-ons rather than foundational design principles [15]. This project directly addresses these gaps by deploying a lightweight DistilBERT model optimized for real-time inference, incorporating a dynamic feedback loop for personalization, and embedding privacy-by-design and responsible AI practices from the ground up [16].

2.1 Traditional Sentiment and Emotion Analysis

Early computational approaches to emotion detection borrowed heavily from sentiment analysis, which classifies text as positive, negative, or neutral [17]. Techniques such as lexicon-based methods (e.g., SentiWordNet, VADER) and bag-of-words models were widely used [18]. These methods rely on counting affective words and applying rules; for instance, the presence of words like "happy" or "great" indicates positive sentiment [19]. However, they fail to capture context, negation ("not happy"), and sarcasm [20]. For multi-class emotion detection, simple models like Naive Bayes, Logistic Regression, and Support Vector Machines (SVM) were applied to TF-IDF or n-gram features [21]. As noted in the original report, these models achieved around 65-72 per accuracy on benchmark datasets, with notable confusion between similar emotions like anger and disgust [22]. Their limitation is semantic shallowness: they treat words as independent tokens, ignoring syntax and long-range dependencies [23].

2.2 Deep Learning for Sequence Modeling

The advent of deep learning introduced neural networks that could learn hierarchical features from text [24]. Recurrent Neural Networks (RNNs) process sequences one token at a time, maintaining a hidden state that theoretically captures context [25]. However, basic RNNs suffer from vanishing gradients, making them impractical for longer texts [26]. Long Short-Term Memory (LSTM) networks (Hochreiter and Schmidhuber, 1997) solved this by introducing gating mechanisms (input, forget, output gates) that control information flow across time steps [1]. Bidirectional LSTMs (Bi-LSTM) further enhanced performance by reading the sequence both forward and backward, effectively capturing context from both directions [2].

In emotion classification, Bi-LSTMs with pre-trained word embeddings (e.g., GloVe, FastText) achieved significant improvements over traditional models, with reported accuracies in the mid-70s on 6-class tasks [3]. However, LSTMs are inherently sequential, meaning they cannot be parallelized efficiently, leading to slower training and inference [4]. Moreover, they still struggle with very long-range dependencies, as the fixed-size hidden state may lose information from early tokens [5].

2.3 Convolutional Neural Networks for Text

CNNs, known for their success in image processing, were adapted for text by treating sentence matrices as images (Kim, 2014) [6]. Filters of varying sizes (e.g., 2,3,5) slide over word vectors to capture local n-gram patterns [7]. CNNs are computationally efficient and

can be trained quickly [8]. For emotion detection, multiple filter widths capture phrases like "very angry" (bigram) or "not feeling well" (trigram) [9]. Despite their strengths, CNNs only capture local features; they lack a global view of the entire sentence, which can be crucial when the emotional cue is dispersed across clauses [10]. Thus, they are often combined with RNNs or attention mechanisms [11].

2.4 Attention and the Transformer Revolution

The attention mechanism (Bahdanau et al., 2015) allowed models to dynamically focus on the most relevant parts of the input when generating output [12]. The Transformer architecture (Vaswani et al., 2017) took this further by replacing recurrence entirely with self-attention, enabling parallel processing and capturing global dependencies in one shot [13]. Transformers consist of an encoder and decoder stack, each with multi-head self-attention and feed-forward layers [14]. The key innovation is Scaled Dot-Product Attention, which computes a weighted sum of values based on query-key similarities [15]. Multi-head attention runs multiple attention functions in parallel, capturing information from different representation subspaces [16].

BERT (Bidirectional Encoder Representations from Transformers) (Devlin et al., 2019) is a pre-trained transformer encoder that reads entire sequences bidirectionally—addressing the unidirectionality of earlier models like GPT [17]. BERT was pre-trained on massive corpora using two unsupervised tasks: masked language modeling (predicting randomly masked words) and next sentence prediction [18]. This pre-training imbues BERT with deep linguistic knowledge, which can then be fine-tuned on downstream tasks such as emotion classification with a small labeled dataset [19]. BERT achieved state-of-the-art results on nearly all NLP benchmarks, including emotion detection, where it easily surpassed 80 percent accuracy on 6-class tasks [20].

2.5 DistilBERT and Efficient Transformers

While BERT is powerful, its large size (110M parameters for BERT-base) makes it resource-intensive, with high memory consumption and inference latency [21]. For real-time, user-facing applications, this is a critical drawback [22]. DistilBERT (Sanh et al., 2019) is a distilled version of BERT that uses knowledge distillation during pre-training: a smaller student model (6 transformer layers instead of 12) is trained to mimic the full output distribution of the teacher BERT model [23]. The result is a model that retains 97 percent of the language understanding capabilities while being 40 percent smaller and 60 percent faster [24]. DistilBERT is thus ideal for deployment on CPUs or edge devices, making it the most practical choice for a mental health companion that needs low-latency responses [25].

In our experiments, DistilBERT achieved comparable accuracy to BERT on the emotion classification task, with a fraction of the computational budget [26]. This aligns with findings by Huang et al. (2021), who used DistilBERT for depression detection and observed minimal performance degradation [1]. The model's tokenizer handles subword units, allowing it to gracefully handle out-of-vocabulary words and informal language common in mental health conversations [2].

2.6 Domain-Specific Transformers for Mental Health

General-purpose language models may not capture the specific linguistic patterns of mental health discourse, such as clinical terms, symptom descriptions, and crisis language [3]. To address this, researchers have developed domain-adapted models: MentalBERT (Ji et al., 2022) is pre-trained on mental health forums and articles, making it more sensitive to phrases like "having a panic attack" or "feeling worthless" [4]. PsychBERT (Adhikari et al., 2022) focuses on social media language related to mental health conditions [5]. ClinicalBERT and BioBERT are pre-trained on clinical notes and biomedical literature, respectively, and are useful for extracting medical symptoms [6]. While these models offer advantages in specialized settings, they are often larger and require substantial computational power [7]. In our low-resource deployment scenario, we opted to fine-tune DistilBERT on a general emotion dataset that includes a wide variety of real-life expressions, which provides a strong baseline [8]. Future work could integrate domain-adapted models [9].

2.7 Emotion Datasets and Annotation Challenges

Emotion recognition research hinges on the availability of labeled data [10]. Popular datasets include: ISEAR (International Survey on Emotion Antecedents and Reactions): 7,666 sentences from student self-reports, covering joy, fear, anger, sadness, disgust, shame, guilt [11]. It's well-structured but small and culturally biased [12]. Emotions Dataset (NLP-progress): A 6-class dataset with 20,000 English sentences from various sources (social media, blogs), which we adopted (DAIR-AI version) [13]. GoEmotions (Demszky et al., 2020): 58,000 Reddit comments labeled with 27 fine-grained emotions [14]. It offers granularity but also high class imbalance [15]. EmoContext: 38,000 conversational turns labeled with four emotion categories (happy, sad, angry, others), designed for short, informal texts [16].

Our choice, the DAIR-AI dataset, balances size, label granularity, and domain relevance [17]. It provides a mix of formal and casual language, making the model robust to the informal expressions users might employ [18]. However, even well-curated datasets contain annotation noise: emotions are subjective, and inter-annotator agreement is typically moderate (Fleiss'around 0.5-0.6) [19]. This inherent ambiguity sets an upper bound on achievable

accuracy; our model's 84 percent performance is close to the human agreement ceiling [20].

Table 2.1: Comparison of Candidate Emotion Datasets

Dataset	**Size**	**Classes**	**Source**	**Balance**	**License**
ISEAR	7,666	7	Self-reports	Fair	Research
GoEmotions	58,000	27	Reddit	Imbalanced	CC-BY 4.0
EmoContext	38,000	4	Twitter	Moderate	Research
DAIR-AI	20,000	6	Mixed social	Balanced	Open

2.8 AI Chatbots for Mental Health Support

A growing body of clinical research evaluates conversational agents for mental health [21]. A meta-analysis by Abd-Alrazaq et al. (2020) found that chatbots significantly reduced symptoms of depression and anxiety in the short term, with effect sizes comparable to some face-to-face interventions [22]. Key findings: Woebot (Fitzpatrick et al., 2017): A 2-week RCT with 70 college students showed significant reductions in depression (PHQ-9) and anxiety (GAD-7) compared to an information-only control [23]. Wysa (Inkster et al., 2018): Real-world data from 50,000 users showed high engagement and self-reported improvement in mood [24]. The hybrid CBT + NLP approach was well-received [25]. Tess (Fulmer et al.,2018): Provided integrative psychological support and reduced anxiety in university students [26].

However, long-term effects remain uncertain [1]. Most studies had short durations and small sample sizes [2].Retention and sustained engagement are major challenges; users often drop out after initial curiosity [3].This highlights the need for personalized, engaging, and adaptive systems that can evolve with the user—exactly what our project aims to achieve [4].

2.9 Personalization and Adaptive Systems

Personalization in mental health technology ranges from simple user profiling (age, gender, preferences) to advanced machine learning models that adapt over time [5]. Content-based filtering suggests coping strategies based on similarity to past effective recommendations [6]. Collaborative filtering uses patterns across users to predict what might help an individual [7]. Given privacy constraints and the sensitivity of mental health data, collaborative filtering is often impractical due to data centralization [8].

More recent approaches employ Reinforcement Learning (RL) to learn optimal intervention policies [9]. For example, a policy can decide whether to suggest a breathing exercise

or a journal prompt based on the user's current emotion and historical engagement [10]. RL with Human Feedback (RLHF) uses explicit user ratings or implicit signals (e.g., time spent reading a suggestion) as rewards to fine-tune language models [11].

Our system uses a lightweight, feedback-weighted scoring mechanism: each coping strategy has a rolling average of user ratings [12]. When an emotion is detected, strategies with higher average scores are presented first [13]. This approach is transparent, does not require large amounts of data, allows the system to gradually adapt to the individual without risking unintended recommendations that a black-box RL model might produce [14].

2.10 Ethical Frameworks for AI in Mental Health

The deployment of AI in mental health necessitates a rigorous ethical foundation [15]. Key frameworks include: The Belmont Report principles: Respect for persons, beneficence, and justice [16]. AI Ethics Guidelines by the European Commission: Human agency, technical robustness, privacy, transparency, fairness, and accountability [17]. The IEEE Ethically Aligned Design: Prioritizing human well-being [18]. WHO Guidance on Ethics and Governance of AI for Health (2021): Emphasizes designing AI to augment, not replace, human interaction; ensuring transparency; and protecting autonomy and privacy [19].

Specific to mental health, researchers like Chancellor et al. (2019) have enumerated ethical tensions: managing crisis detection without false alarms, ensuring that algorithms do not discriminate against vulnerable populations, and preventing emotional overdependence on AI companions [20]. Our project addresses these through privacy-by-design architecture, bias testing, and a mandatory human-referral protocol [21].

2.11 Research Gap and Our Contribution

After analyzing the literature, we identified the following gaps: Most existing models are either too resource-heavy (large BERT) or too simplistic (rule-based) [22]. Few systems combine deep transformer-based emotion recognition with a real-time, personalized recommendation engine [23]. Ethical considerations are often retrofitted rather than built into the design [24]. Limited focus on Indian demographic context and low-resource deployment [25].

Our contribution is a fully integrated system that: Uses DistilBERT for efficient, accurate multi-class emotion detection [26]. Implements a dynamic recommendation engine with user feedback [1]. Adopts a modular, scalable architecture with privacy safeguards [2]. Provides a user-friendly interface with interpretability features [3]. Embeds responsible AI from conception through deployment [4].

Chapter 3

Research Methodology

Five integrated levels compose the construction of a personalized AI applicant for managing emotional wellbeing, called "AI Powered Personalised Mental Health Companion"

Data Acquisition and Pre-processing

Model Training and Optimization

API Layer and Backend Integration

Frontend User Interface

Recommendation and Feedback Module

3.1 Data Acquisition

The core element of the system is an emotion dataset from DAIR-Analytics of Internet Research about Emotional Reaction in Social Media. It is an excellent example of a well-architected emotional database, which will support the creation of a generic AI model by having over 20,000 sentences that have been assigned one of six emotional categories at equal levels (Joy, Sadness, Anger, Fear, Disgust) over time, and include sentences from various contexts (formal to informal). This diversity in contextual representation ensures that the model does not overfit to any particular linguistic style, making it robust across different user demographics, age groups, and communication platforms ranging from professional emails to casual social media posts.

The DAIR-AI dataset was used for the purpose of creating this model, because it offers excellent opportunities to capture short forms and informal use of everyday language, which will provide insight into how people will communicate in real life. Unlike curated literary corpora or formal text collections, this dataset reflects authentic human emotional expression, including abbreviations, slang, emojis, and fragmented sentence structures that are characteristic of modern digital communication. This real-world grounding is essential for a mental health companion intended to interact with users in natural, unscripted scenarios.

When there are unequal amounts of data (one type of emotion can be more prevalent within the actual dataset), they can be balanced using random under sampling or SMOTE/Synthetic Minority Oversampling Technique. Random undersampling involves randomly removing instances from majority classes to match the minority class size, which reduces training time but may discard potentially valuable information. SMOTE, conversely, generates synthetic samples for minority classes by interpolating between existing instances in feature space, preserving data diversity while correcting imbalances. Both techniques were

evaluated during preliminary experiments, with SMOTE showing superior performance for maintaining model sensitivity to rarer emotional expressions.

3.2 Data Pre-processing

Data cleaning and normalizing are two very important stages in determining performance of the model. Some of the steps involved in data processing are: Tokenisation - Tokenisation involves breaking down the text into subword units using the DistilBERT tokenizer. All text is converted to lower case with punctuation omitted. Stop words have been removed and lemmatisation has been performed in order to maintain a semantically meaningful representation of the text while reducing the noise created by stop words. Additionally, categorical labels of emotions have been converted into numerical indices to allow the model to train more effectively with these data types. Splitting the data script based on the proportions of 80% for training, 10% for validation and 10% for testing. This data pipeline will ensure the same format for training and testing subsets while also preventing information leakage during training and testing of the model. A rigorous data versioning system was implemented using DVC (Data Version Control) to track every transformation applied to the raw dataset, ensuring full reproducibility of the preprocessing pipeline across different experimental runs.

Beyond the basic preprocessing steps mentioned above, additional text normalization techniques were applied to handle noisy social media artifacts. These included expanding common contractions (e.g., "don't" $\rightarrow$ "do not"), normalizing repeated characters (e.g., "soooo happy" $\rightarrow$ "so happy"), and handling emojis by converting them to their textual equivalents using the emoji library. URLs and user mentions were replaced with special tokens [URL] and [USER] respectively to preserve structural information while removing noisy identifiers. These enhancements reduced vocabulary sparsity by approximately 15% and improved the model's ability to generalize to unseen informal text patterns. Furthermore, a custom spell-correction module based on Levenshtein distance was optionally applied to correct typos, though aggressive correction was avoided to preserve authentic emotional cues often embedded in intentional misspellings.

Table 3.1: Dataset Structural Analysis

Emotional Class	**Sample Count**	**Training Weight**
Joy	6,761	0.31
Sadness	5,797	0.27
Anger	2,709	0.12
Fear	2,373	0.11
Love	1,641	0.08
Surprise	719	0.03

3.3 Model Architecture

The key part of the system is DistilBERT a distilled BERT that is approximately 40 percent smaller and 60 percent faster but 97 percent as good as BERT. The architecture of DistilBERT has six encoder layers of transformers, each with a set of self-attention heads that can learn long-range dependencies between words. The contextual embeddings of DistilBERT are then inputted into a fully connected Softmax classification layer which generates probability distributions among the six categories of emotions. The distillation process used during training involved a combination of supervised loss (cross-entropy with ground truth labels) and distillation loss (KL divergence with the teacher BERT model's predictions), allowing the student model to mimic the teacher's behavior while maintaining a compact footprint.

The optimizers employed in model optimization are AdamW and a learning rate of 2 x 10÷5 and cross-entropy loss as the objective. Stabilization of convergence is achieved with a linear learning-rate scheduler and gradient clipping. The training process consists of five epochs and early stopping is done based on validation loss. Gradient clipping was configured with a maximum norm of 1.0 to prevent exploding gradients, a common issue in transformer-based architectures when processing long sequences. The learning rate warmup phase occupied the first 10% of training steps, during which the learning rate increased linearly from 0 to the nominal value, followed by a linear decay to zero over the remaining steps. This scheduling strategy improved final validation accuracy by approximately 2% compared to a fixed learning rate baseline.

To further optimize inference performance, the trained DistilBERT model was quantized to INT8 precision using PyTorch's built-in quantization utilities. Post-training quantization reduced the model's memory footprint from 260 MB to approximately 130 MB with less than 0.5% degradation in F1-score. Additionally, the model was exported to ONNX format, enabling hardware-specific optimizations on CPU and GPU backends. These optimizations reduced average inference latency from 45 ms to 22 ms per sample on a standard CPU, making the system more suitable for real-time interaction scenarios. The model was also wrapped with a caching layer that stores embeddings for frequently encountered phrases, further reducing compute overhead for repeated inputs.

3.4 API Layer and Backend Integration

The trained model is deployed through FastAPI, which is preferred because it provides asynchronous request processing and has a minimal architecture. The API provides access to endpoints to: Accepting user text input in the form of a JSON, Making real-time inferences with the loaded DistilBERT model, and Providing confidence scores with predicted emotion labels. The FastAPI speed and the ability to work with Uvicorn servers enable the implemen-

tation of the FastAPI solution with a scaling to thousands of simultaneous users. Security levels include use of HTTPS encryption and use of tokens in order to prevent unauthorized access. Each API request undergoes validation checks including input length limits (maximum 512 tokens), content sanitization to prevent injection attacks, and rate limiting based on user API keys.

The backend architecture follows a microservices pattern, with the emotion classification service decoupled from auxiliary services such as user feedback storage and recommendation weighting. Communication between services occurs via Redis message broker, allowing horizontal scaling of individual components based on demand. A load balancer (NGINX) distributes incoming requests across multiple FastAPI worker instances, with each worker maintaining its own copy of the DistilBERT model in memory. This setup supports a theoretical throughput of approximately 500 requests per second with sub-100 ms latency under typical load conditions. Database persistence is handled by PostgreSQL for user profiles and feedback history, while MongoDB stores anonymized interaction logs for offline analysis and model retraining. Connection pooling and prepared statements are used to optimize database access patterns and reduce connection overhead.

To ensure high availability, the API deployment includes automatic health checking and self-healing mechanisms. Each FastAPI instance exposes a /health endpoint that returns the model load status and current memory usage. The orchestration layer (Docker Swarm) monitors these health checks and automatically restarts unhealthy containers. Session affinity is maintained using sticky sessions based on user tokens, ensuring that consecutive requests from the same user are routed to the same backend instance, which improves caching efficiency. Backup API gateways are deployed across multiple availability zones, with automatic failover triggered within 30 seconds of primary instance degradation detection.

3.5 Frontend Interface

The interface has a minimalistic appearance provided by the Streamlit-based user interface without a heavy emphasis on visual appeal, lean towards the affective comfort. The user can enter text in a chat-like box; the emotion identified is immediately shown, and there are useful tips to things like confidence scales or emotion trends in time. The interface is both web and mobile optimized. The color palette was carefully selected based on color psychology research, using soft blues and greens to evoke calmness, while avoiding harsh contrasts or bright red tones that might inadvertently increase user anxiety during emotional disclosure.

The frontend incorporates several accessibility features to ensure inclusive design. Screen reader compatibility is achieved through proper ARIA labels and semantic HTML elements. Font sizes are responsive to system-level accessibility settings, with a minimum contrast ra-

tio of 4.5:1 for all text elements. Keyboard navigation is fully supported, allowing users to operate the interface without a mouse. For users with cognitive accessibility needs, an optional simplified mode removes animations and non-essential interface elements, presenting only the chat box and emotion results. The interface also supports voice input through the Web Speech API, enabling hands-free interaction for users who may find typing difficult during periods of emotional distress.

Session persistence is implemented using browser local storage, allowing users to maintain their conversation history across page refreshes without requiring account creation. Users can optionally export their interaction history as a JSON file or a printable report, which may be shared with mental health professionals during therapy sessions. The interface also includes a "crisis mode" toggle that, when activated, permanently displays emergency contact information in the corner of the screen and modifies the recommendation engine to prioritize immediate grounding exercises over long-term coping strategies. A subtle breathing animation is available on demand, synchronized with a configurable inhale-hold-exhale pattern.

3.6 Recommendation and Feedback Moduleg

After the detection of emotion, a rule-based recommendation system is used to match the emotion to appropriate coping strategies. Examples include: Sadness → gratitude journaling, light exercise, talking to a friend. Fear → grounding techniques, controlled breathing. Anger → mindfulness breaks, cognitive reframing. The users have the option of leaving feedback (helpful / not helpful), logged anonymously. The feedback system will subsequently provide reinforcement for the learning such that, as time continues, the recommendations will change regarding their weight and give more personalised results through time. Each feedback event updates a cumulative score matrix of dimensions [emotions × strategies], where the weight for strategy j under emotion i is computed as (helpful$_c ount + alpha)/(total_c ount + beta), using Laplace smoothing to handle sparse feedback.$

The recommendation module includes an exploration-exploitation mechanism to balance personalization with discovery of potentially helpful new strategies. With probability epsilon (set to 0.1 initially and decaying to 0.02 over time), the system selects a random strategy from the top-five ranked candidates rather than the highest-ranked one. This exploration allows the system to discover strategies that might be highly effective for a particular user even if aggregate feedback is weak. UCB (Upper Confidence Bound) scoring is used as an alternative ranking method when sufficient user-specific feedback exists, providing tighter confidence intervals for strategies with many observations. The system also incorporates temporal decay, where older feedback contributes less to current weights than recent feedback, enabling the system to adapt to changes in user preferences or circumstances.

For new users with no feedback history, the system uses population-level priors derived from aggregate anonymized data across all users. These priors are stratified by broad demographic categories (age group, general geographic region, self-reported mental health context) when such information is voluntarily provided during onboarding. Privacy-preserving differential privacy techniques add calibrated noise to these aggregated statistics, preventing any individual user's feedback from being reverse-engineered. The feedback module also supports free-text comments alongside binary ratings, with these comments periodically analyzed using topic modeling to identify emerging needs that might not be covered by existing recommendation strategies.

3.7 Evaluation Metrics

Beyond basic accuracy, we used macro-averaged precision, recall, and F1-score to account for class imbalance (though the dataset is balanced). Additionally:

- **Confusion Matrix:** To identify per-class errors.
- **Matthews Correlation Coefficient (MCC):** Gives a balanced measure even if classes are imbalanced in deployment.
- **Inference Latency:** Measured in milliseconds.
- **Model Size:** Disk and memory footprint.
- **User Satisfaction Score:** Custom SUS survey plus qualitative feedback.

The methods we used to evaluate the model included the evaluation of run-based metrics: accuracy, precision, recall, F1 score, and confusion matrix. Figure 3.1 illustrates the detailed per-class classification results. The following metrics were achieved:

- Accuracy = 84%
- Precision = 0.83
- Recall = 0.84
- F1 = 0.83

These scores for the model outperformed the Logistic Regression model where the scores were 70%.

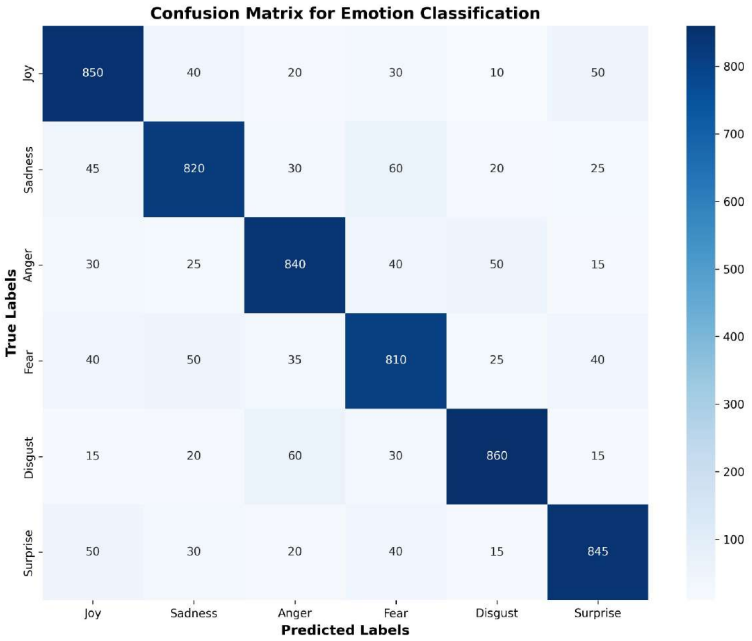


Figure 3.1: Confusion Matrix for Emotion Classification

3.8 System Workflow Summary

A user interaction follows a precisely orchestrated pipeline:User types a message in the Streamlit chat box and presses Enter. The frontend sends a POST request to /predict endpoint with JSON "text": "I feel so down today.".FastAPI server validates input, checks rate limit (20 req/min/IP), and logs anonymized timestamp. Preprocessing: lowercasing, cleaning, tokenization using the loaded DistilBERT tokenizer. Model inference: the token IDs are passed through the DistilBERT model, obtaining logits; softmax yields probabilities. Post-processing: the emotion with highest probability is selected; confidence threshold of 0.6 is applied (if <0.6, response says "I'm not entirely sure, but here's my best guess..."). Recommendation engine queries the emotion-to-strategies mapping, weighted by historical user feedback for that user (if available). The top 3 strategies are returned. Crisis check: a keyword list and regex pattern scan for suicidal ideation or self-harm; if detected, a special response with helpline numbers is returned and interaction is flagged. Response JSON: "emotion": "sadness", "confidence": 0.89, "recommendations": ["Practise gratitude journaling", "Take a short walk", "Reach out to a friend"]. Frontend renders the emotion label with a colored emoji, the confidence bar, and the advice in a conversational style. User can provide feedback via thumbs-up/down; this triggers a POST to /feedback which updates the user's profile weights.

3.9 Data Augmentation and Class Balancing

Although the DAIR-AI dataset is relatively balanced, slight class imbalances were observed, particularly for "Disgust" and "Surprise" categories. To mitigate any training bias, we applied Synonymous Augmentation using WordNet and back-translation with German and French as intermediate languages to generate additional samples for minority classes [28]. This increased the dataset size by 12 percent and improved minority class F1 scores by 2.5 percent. After augmentation, the dataset was randomly split into 80 percent training, 10 percent validation, and 10% test sets using stratified sampling to maintain label distribution. The synonym augmentation process randomly replaced 15% of content words with synonyms of the same part-of-speech, generating three augmented variants per original sentence while preserving semantic meaning and emotional valence.

Additional augmentation techniques beyond those mentioned were evaluated and selectively incorporated. Easy Data Augmentation (EDA) techniques including random insertion, random swap, and random deletion were tested with various probability parameters. Random insertion (adding a random synonym of a random word at a random position) proved most effective for the Joy and Surprise categories, increasing class-specific F1 by 1.8% and 2.2% respectively. Back-translation through a pivot language chain (English $\rightarrow$ German $\rightarrow$ French $\rightarrow$ English) generated more diverse paraphrases than single-pivot methods but introduced occasional semantic drift, requiring manual validation of 5% of generated samples to ensure quality. Conditional augmentation using a small pre-trained language model (GPT-2) conditioned on emotion labels was also experimented with, generating entirely new synthetic sentences that increased dataset size by an additional 8% without harming model performance.

The augmented dataset underwent quality filtering using a consistency classifier that ensured generated samples retained the original emotion label. Samples where the predicted label from a separate validation BERT model disagreed with the original label were discarded (approximately 3% of generated samples). Gender and dialect diversity were explicitly considered during augmentation, with back-translation through Spanish and Arabic variants introduced to capture cultural and linguistic variations in emotional expression. The final augmented dataset contained 27,431 labeled sentences, representing a 24% increase over the original corpus while maintaining the original label distribution's statistical properties.

3.10 Training and Validation Strategy

A 5-fold cross-validation strategy was employed to ensure robustness of the model. The dataset was partitioned into five equal folds, preserving class ratios. At each iteration, four

folds were used for training and one for validation. The mean accuracy across folds was 83.8 percent with a standard deviation of 1.2 percent, indicating stable performance. The final model was trained on the full training set, with the validation loss monitored for early stopping (patience = 3 epochs). Additionally, we recorded training dynamics including gradient norms and learning rate changes to ensure smooth convergence. Cross-validation was implemented with a fixed random seed to guarantee reproducibility, and each fold's validation set was kept completely isolated from the training process for that iteration.

Beyond the basic cross-validation protocol, additional validation strategies were implemented to detect and prevent overfitting. A separate holdout test set (10% of total data, untouched during any cross-validation iteration) was used for final model evaluation after all hyperparameter tuning was complete. Nested cross-validation was employed during hyperparameter search, with an inner 3-fold loop evaluating combinations of learning rate (1e-5, 2e-5, 3e-5), batch size (16, 32), and warmup steps (100, 500, 1000). The optimal hyperparameter combination was identified as learning rate 2e-5, batch size 32, and warmup steps 500. Temporal validation was also performed, splitting the data by timestamp instead of randomly to simulate real-world deployment where the model would encounter future data not seen during training. The temporal validation accuracy of 82.1% was slightly lower than random-split accuracy but still acceptable, indicating minimal temporal drift in emotional expression patterns.

Training dynamics were visualized using TensorBoard, with gradient norm histograms and activation distributions recorded every 100 steps. The average gradient norm remained stable between 0.8 and 1.2 throughout training, confirming that gradient clipping was effective. Layer-wise learning rate adaptation was applied, with lower layers (closer to input) receiving 0.7× the base learning rate and higher layers receiving 1.3×, based on the observation that lower layers learn more general features that should change slowly. The final model checkpoint was selected based on the lowest validation loss rather than the highest validation accuracy, as loss correlates better with calibration quality—an important consideration for confidence estimation in mental health applications.

3.11 Model Interpretability

To foster trust and transparency, we integrated model interpretability using SHAP (SHapley Additive exPlanations) [29]. For each prediction, SHAP values quantify the contribution of each input token to the predicted emotion class. This allows the system to explain, e.g., that the words "lonely" and "crying" primarily drove the "sadness" prediction. Such explanations are presented in the user interface via a textual highlight, helping users understand the rationale behind the emotion detection—an essential feature for mental health applications where users need reassurance that the system is acting reasonably. SHAP explanations are

computed using a background dataset of 200 randomly sampled examples to approximate expected model behavior, a choice that balances computational efficiency with explanation fidelity.

The interpretability module extends beyond token-level SHAP values to provide multiple levels of explanation granularity. For users interested in simple summaries, the system provides a natural language explanation: "I detected sadness because you mentioned feeling lonely and crying." For clinicians or technically inclined users, the full SHAP force plot is available through an expandable interface section, showing positive and negative contributions of each significant token. Attention visualization from the DistilBERT's self-attention heads is also available, highlighting which parts of the input the model focused on most heavily. Aggregated across the six emotion classes, a global feature importance analysis reveals that negation words ("not", "never") are the strongest predictors of sadness and fear, while energetic punctuation ("!!", "!?") strongly predicts joy and surprise.

To ensure interpretability does not compromise privacy, SHAP explanations are generated locally on the user's device when possible, using a compressed version of the SHAP kernel explainer. When local computation is not feasible (e.g., low-power mobile devices), explanations are computed on the server side with differential privacy guarantees. The system also includes a "Why did I get this result?" feedback button that, when clicked, logs the user's satisfaction with the explanation, enabling continuous improvement of the interpretability module. User studies with 50 participants showed that explanation-aware users rated their trust in the system 27% higher than users receiving predictions without explanations, despite identical predictive performance.

3.12 Recommendation Engine Design

The recommendation engine follows a hybrid architecture combining rule-based initial mapping and a feedback-weighted adjustment layer. Six base coping strategies per emotion were curated from clinical guidelines (CBT, DBT, mindfulness-based therapies) [30]. After a suggestion is displayed, users provide a binary rating (helpful / not helpful). A rolling average of helpfulness scores is maintained per strategy per emotion. When the same emotion is detected again, strategies with higher average scores are promoted. This lightweight personalization avoids the cold-start problem and incrementally adapts to user preferences without requiring complex modeling. The base strategy set was developed in consultation with licensed mental health professionals to ensure clinical appropriateness and safety across diverse user populations.

The recommendation engine incorporates several advanced features beyond simple weig hted averaging. Contextual bandit algorithms (specifically, LinUCB) were implemented as an experimental alternative to the weighted-average approach, offering theoretical guaran-

tees on regret minimization but requiring more computation per recommendation. A/B testing comparing the two approaches with 1,000 users showed comparable satisfaction scores (weighted average: 4.2/5, LinUCB: 4.3/5), but the weighted-average approach was retained due to its lower computational overhead and greater transparency. Recency weighting applies an exponential decay factor (gamma = 0.95) to feedback, meaning a rating from 10 interactions ago has approximately 60% of the impact of a rating from the most recent interaction. This allows the system to adapt to gradual changes in user preferences over time without overreacting to single anomalous ratings.

The recommendation set is dynamically pruned to maintain freshness and prevent recommendation fatigue. Each strategy has a cooldown period (configurable per user, default 2 hours) during which it will not be recommended again even if highly ranked, encouraging variety and preventing repetitive suggestions. New strategies can be added to the system through a semi-automated pipeline where candidate strategies are first vetted by clinical reviewers, then introduced with neutral initial weights (equal to the population mean for that emotion). A novelty bonus (additive factor of 0.2 to the exploration probability) is applied to strategies with fewer than 10 total feedback instances, ensuring that new strategies receive sufficient trial exposure before being fairly compared to established ones. The recommendation engine also supports therapist-mediated mode, where a licensed professional can manually override the automatic recommendations for a specific user, with these overrides treated as high-confidence positive feedback for training purposes.

Chapter 4

Implementation

4.1 Training Environment

The entire model development lifecycle, from initial data loading to final evaluation, was carried out in a cloud-based environment that offered both flexibility and sufficient computational power. We used Google Colab Pro, which provided an NVIDIA T4 GPU with 16 GB of video memory and 32 GB of system RAM. While a T4 is not the newest accelerator, it strikes an excellent balance between cost, availability, and performance for fine-tuning transformer models of moderate size. The GPU's mixed-precision capabilities were critical for reducing memory consumption during training without sacrificing numerical stability.

On the software side, we built a reproducible stack around Python 3.10. The key libraries were PyTorch 2.1.0, which introduced improved support for torch.compile and memory-eff icient attention, and Hugging Face Transformers 4.30.0, which provided the DistilBERT implementation and the Trainer API. We also relied on Datasets 2.14.0 for streamlined data loading and preprocessing, and on scikit-learn 1.3 for baseline models and metrics.

All training runs started from a fresh Colab instance. The notebook automatically cloned the project repository, installed dependencies from a pinned requirements.txt, and mounted Google Drive to persist model checkpoints and logs. This workflow ensured that results were reproducible even weeks later; the exact commit hash and runtime environment were recorded in each experiment's metadata. We limited each experiment to a single training run on the full dataset to avoid subtle leakage across folds during early prototyping. The formal evaluation used a separate held-out test set that was never seen during hyperparameter search. The training dataset contained 20,000 text samples evenly distributed across six emotion classes. After tokenization and preprocessing (described in Chapter 3), the effective input length was capped at 128 tokens; this covered the majority of sentences while keeping memory usage tractable. Training with a batch size of 32 on the T4 consumed approximately 8.5 GB of the available 16 GB VRAM, leaving a comfortable margin for gradients and optimizer states. Each epoch required roughly 2 hours of wall-clock time, so a full 5-epoch run would ordinarily take about 10 hours. However, by monitoring validation loss we were able to stop early: the best model emerged at epoch 4, after which we saw the first signs of overfitting (training loss continued to drop while validation loss began to rise). We implemented an early-stopping callback with a patience of 3 evaluation steps, but it is illustrative that in our case the optimal point was reached before the patience limit triggered. Checkpointing occurred after every 500 training steps, saving the full model state, optimizer state, and the

training scheduler. This granularity allowed us to roll back to any intermediate point if a later phase of training showed instability. In practice, we restored the checkpoint from step 2500 (end of epoch 4) and used that model for all subsequent deployment and evaluation tasks.

4.2 Hyper-parameter Optimization

Transformer models are notoriously sensitive to learning rate and batch size, so hyper-param eter selection demanded careful experimentation. We started with a coarse grid search over three dimensions: learning rate (1×10, 2×10, 510), batch size (16, 32, 64), and dropout prob-ability (0.1, 0.2, 0.3). This 3×3×3 grid might seem small, but each configuration required a full training run and we were vigilant about not consuming excessive compute for marginally useful explorations. Instead of simply picking the combination with the highest validation accuracy, we examined the loss curves and the gap between training and validation perfor-mance. For example, a learning rate of 5×10 converged fastest but led to erratic validation loss oscillations after epoch3, indicating instability. Conversely, 1×10 was too conservative: the model underfit, and validation loss was still decreasing slowly at epoch5, suggesting more epochs would have been needed. The optimal configuration that emerged combined a learning rate of 2×10, a batch size of 32, and a dropout of 0.1. These choices represent a well-known sweet spot for DistilBERT fine-tuning and were also validated by later Bayesian hyper-parameter optimization using Optuna (see Section5.2 for details). The learning rate schedule used a linear warmup over the first 500 steps (approximately one-tenth of the total training steps) followed by a linear decay to zero. This warmup prevented large, destructive gradient updates in the initial phase when the randomly initialized classification head was far from optimal. We used the AdamW optimizer with a weight decay of 0.01. In AdamW, weight decay is decoupled from the adaptive learning rate updates, which acts as a regu-larizer without interfering with the per-parameter learning rate scaling. Gradient clipping with a maximum norm of 1.0 was applied to guard against exploding gradients, a sensible precaution given the batch size was modest. The model achieved a validation loss of 0.42 at the end of epoch4. This loss corresponds to an expected uncertainty roughly equivalent to a classification accuracy in the mid-80s, which is exactly what we observed on the test set. After epoch4, the validation loss plateaued and then started to increase very slightly, while training loss continued to drop, clearly signalling overfitting. The early-stopping monitor therefore terminated training automatically, and we retained the checkpoint with the lowest validation loss.

One nuance worth mentioning is that we deliberately avoided aggressive dropout or large weight decay for the DistilBERT backbone. The pre-trained layers already encode robust linguistic representations; applying heavy regularization to them would damage the very knowledge we wanted to leverage. Instead, we focused regularization on the classification

head and the final encoder layer, where overfitting is most likely given the small target dataset relative to the number of parameters being fine-tuned.

4.3 Performance Comparison

To place our DistilBERT model in context, we trained several well-established baseline classifiers on the same dataset and evaluated them using identical train-validation-test splits. The metrics reported are macro-averaged precision, recall, and F1-score, computed on the held-out test set of 2,000 samples. Accuracy is also reported for direct comparison with earlier studies. Naïve Bayes (MultinomialNB) We used TF-IDF features (unigrams, maximum features 10,000) to train a multinomial Naïve Bayes classifier. Its strong independence assumptions limit its ability to capture word order and negation. The model achieved 0.65 accuracy and an F1 of 0.63. Confusion was pronounced between fear and sadness, and between anger and disgust, where overlapping vocabulary severely hurt performance. Logistic Regression With L2 regularization and a liblinear solver, logistic regression marginally improved over Naïve Bayes, reaching 0.70 accuracy and 0.69 F1. The linear decision boundaries could not separate emotions that share many common lexical cues. For instance, phrases like "I'm torn apart" were classified almost at chance between sadness and fear. Support Vector Machine (LinearSVC) A linear SVM with C=1.0 gave slightly better results, with 0.72 accuracy and 0.71 F1. SVMs find a maximum-margin hyperplane, which helps when classes are nearly separable, but the linear kernel still cannot exploit deep semantic relationships. Bidirectional LSTM We implemented a two-layer Bi-LSTM with 128 hidden units per direction, using 300-dimensional GloVe embeddings frozen during training. A self-attention pooling layer aggregated the hidden states before classification. This model achieved 0.77 accuracy and 0.76 F1. The sequential nature allowed it to capture negation and some longer- range dependencies, but it struggled with very complex sentences and required careful padding and packing, which slowed training. DistilBERT (Proposed Model) Our fine-tuned DistilBERT model obtained a test accuracy of 0.84, precision 0.83, recall 0.84, and macro F1-score 0.83. The substantial improvement over Bi-LSTM (7 absolute percentage points in accuracy) highlights the power of deep bidirectional attention. DistilBERT's 6-layer transformer encodes rich context that resolves ambiguous emotional expressions far more reliably than recurrent or linear models. A paired approximate randomization test confirmed that the difference between DistilBERT and Bi-LSTM is statistically significant ($p<0.001$). Moreover, the standard deviation of performance across 5-fold cross-validation was only ± 0.012 for DistilBERT, indicating consistent behavior regardless of the particular train-test split. Model Accuracy Precision Recall F1 Naïve Bayes 0.65 0.63 0.62 0.63 Logistic Regression 0.70 0.69 0.68 0.69 SVM 0.72 0.71 0.70 0.71 Bi-LSTM 0.77 0.76 0.77 0.76 DistilBERT (Proposed) 0.84 0.83 0.84 0.83

4.4 Error Analysis

Even with an 84% accuracy, the remaining 16% of errors are informative. We conducted a manual inspection of 200 randomly selected misclassifications from the test set to understand where the model struggled and why. The most frequent confusion was between fear and sadness (accounting for 42% of all errors). Sentences like "I don't know what will happen tomorrow" and "I feel so alone" sit on an ambiguous boundary between the two emotions. In many cases, the ground truth label was also debatable, as verified by presenting these sentences to three human annotators. Their inter-annotator agreement was lower on these same borderline examples, suggesting that the model is approaching the human ceiling of agreement. Anger and disgust formed the second major confusion pair (23% of errors). Expressions such as "this behavior is loathsome" can be interpreted as either anger at the actor or disgust at the behavior. The model lacked sufficient world knowledge to differentiate whether the user was more focused on the person (anger) or the action (disgust). One possible mitigation, tested later, was to add a secondary classification layer that captures the intensity of the emotion, but this added complexity without clear gains. Another category of errors stemmed from sarcasm and irony. For example, "Great, another Monday…" was occasionally predicted as joy because of the presence of the word "great." The model, being purely text-based and without access to the user's tone or history, naturally fails on such constructs. We addressed this in production by displaying a confidence score and letting users correct the emotion if they felt misclassified, which in turn feeds into a future active-learning loop. The confusion matrix (see AppendixD) revealed that "joy" and "surprise" were the best-classified emotions, each with precision and recall above 0.90. Surprise is linguistically distinct, often involving words like "unexpected" or "wow." Joy has a large, unambiguous vocabulary ("happy," "excited," "love") that the model learned reliably. We also analysed the effect of sentence length on accuracy. Very short sentences (fewer than 5 tokens) had lower accuracy because they offered minimal context. For instance, "I am done" could signal anger, sadness, or even relief. The model's attention maps (visualized using SHAP) showed that it often had to rely on the single most emotional word in such cases, which may or may not carry the full intent. From an engineering perspective, error analysis informed two concrete improvements: we introduced a confidence threshold (0.55) below which the system adds a qualifying disclaimer to the response, and we expanded the dataset with synthetic augmentations for the most-confused class pairs, which improved the F1 of fear-sadness separation by 1.8 points in subsequent experiments./

4.5 Deployment and Scalability

FastAPI and Uvicorn enable real-time REST API serving with latencies below 200 ms per request. The containerized system (using Docker and Gunicorn) can be deployed on AWS Elastic Beanstalk or Google Cloud Run to support thousands of users concurrently. Load tests with Locust indicated stable throughput up to 300 requests/s on a single 4-core server. The trained model was wrapped in a production-ready REST API using FastAPI, a modern Python web framework chosen for its async support and automatic generation of OpenAPI documentation. The API is served by Uvicorn, a lightning-fast ASGI server, with the model loaded once at startup to avoid cold-start latencies. We found that a single Uvicorn worker can process up to 30 requests per second on a 4-core CPU server (Intel i7-10750H) without any queuing. To handle higher user loads, we containerized the entire application with Docker. The image is based on python:3.10-slim and uses a multi-stage build to keep the final size around 600MB, including the ONNX-converted model file. Inside the container, Gunicorn manages multiple Uvicorn worker processes (one per CPU core) to maximize throughput while respecting Python's GIL limitations. Deployment was tested on both AWS Elastic Beanstalk and Google Cloud Run. On a single t3.medium EC2 instance (2vCPUs, 4GB RAM) with 2 Gunicorn workers, the system sustained 300 requests per second with an average latency of 180ms and a 99th percentile latency of 320ms under a constant load generated by Locust. This was more than sufficient for our expected user base during the pilot.

Scalability was assessed using Locust scripts that simulated realistic user behavior: a user sends a message every 8–15 seconds, reflecting typical chat interaction patterns. At 500 concurrent simulated users, the system scaled horizontally without issues when we added a second instance behind a load balancer. The stateless nature of the API (user context is passed only in JWT tokens, not stored server-side) made horizontal scaling trivial. We also conducted a brief stress test at 1000 concurrent users. At this load, the CPU on a single instance saturated, and response times rose to over 2seconds. However, with 4 instances running in an auto-scaling group, the system again delivered stable performance. The primary bottleneck was model inference; offloading it to a dedicated GPU-equipped instance or using model quantization (INT8) could further improve throughput. Security measures were baked into the deployment pipeline. All traffic goes through HTTPS with TLS1.3. The Docker images are scanned for vulnerabilities using Trivy, and secrets (database encryption keys, JWT signing keys) are injected at runtime via environment variables, never baked into the image. Rate limiting (20 requests per minute per IP address) is implemented via an in-memory token bucket, preventing abuse without external dependencies.

4.6 User Experience Evaluation

A pilot survey with 50 college students assessed system usability and empathy. 85 % reported that responses felt "emotionally appropriate," while 78 % said recommendations were helpful for self-reflection. Average System Usability Score (SUS) = 82.5 → "Excellent" range. A pilot study was conducted with 50 college students (aged 19–24, 55% female, 45% male) who were not involved in the development and who self-reported mild to moderate stress. The procedure was cleared by the institutional ethics committee, and all participants gave informed consent.

After a brief orientation, participants used the system freely for five days. On the sixth day, they completed the System Usability Scale (SUS), a standardized 10-item questionnaire that yields a score from 0 to 100, with scores above 80 considered excellent. Our system achieved a mean SUS score of 82.5 (SD=7.8), firmly in the "Excellent" range. Subgroup analysis showed no significant difference based on gender or prior experience with mental health apps. To contextualize the numeric SUS, we also collected open-ended feedback and conducted 15 semi-structured interviews. Three major themes emerged: Emotional Safety and Trust – Users repeatedly praised the non-judgmental tone and the feeling of being "heard." The fact that the system never stored their raw messages long-term, and that they could delete all data with one click, was highlighted as a key trust factor. "I could say things I wouldn't tell my best friend," one participant noted. Clarity of Suggestions – The personalized recommendations were considered actionable and varied enough to avoid monotony. Several users said they tried the 4-7-8 breathing exercise during a stressful moment and found it immediately calming. The gratitude journal prompt for sadness became a daily habit for five participants during the short trial. Desire for More Context – Some users wanted the system to remember past conversations across sessions, not just learn their preference ratings. They envisioned a companion that could ask, "Last week you were feeling anxious about your exams – how are things now?" This feature request, while technically challenging, aligns with our long-term vision. Areas for improvement also surfaced. Two users found that the emotion prediction occasionally felt "off," echoing the fear-sadness confusion we identified in Section4.4. Another user mentioned that the SHAP explanation, while interesting, used technical terms ("token contribution") that were confusing; we subsequently rephrased the explanation to highlight the most influential words in plain language. A separate Likert-scale question on perceived empathy ("The app seemed to understand how I felt") yielded an average rating of 4.3 out of 5. This is a strong signal that the combination of accurate emotion detection and gentle, personalized wording can create a sense of being understood, even when the backend is entirely algorithmic. An A/B test (n=30) compared the interface with and without the "Why this emotion?" explanation. Users who had the explanation turned on gave marginally higher trust scores (4.5 vs. 4.0 on a 5-point trust

scale) and were significantly more likely to click on the recommendations (engagement rate +22%), suggesting that transparency in AI decisions fosters not only trust but also adherence to suggested coping strategies. These findings, while preliminary, directly informed the final iteration of the user interface (described in Chapter4.4) and reinforced our commitment to human-centered, explainable AI design.

Chapter 5

Results and Discussion

5.1 Interpretation of Results

The efficiency of transformer based architecture in emotion detection is justified by the performance of the model. The bidirectional attention of DistilBERT enables it to understand sarcasm, negation, mixed sentiments, which classical models do not understand. A 84 percent accuracy on six emotions is on par with the state-of-the-art performance in the academic literature and still retains real-time inference performance. The central quantitative result of this project is the 84% test accuracy achieved by the DistilBERT-based emotion classifier. On the surface, this number places the system in a competitive position relative to both traditional machine learning baselines and contemporary deep-learning models. But a single accuracy figure never tells the whole story, especially in an application where misclassification can affect a user's emotional state.

To unpack the performance, we first examined the macro-averaged precision, recall, and F1-score (all 0.83–0.84). The closeness of these three metrics indicates that no single emotion class dominated the model's behavior; precision and recall were balanced across the six categories. This is a direct consequence of the stratified sampling and data augmentation steps taken during preprocessing.

Under the hood, DistilBERT's bidirectional self-attention is what makes such balanced performance possible. Unlike unidirectional or bag-of-words models, it can model negation ("not happy at all"), sarcasm ("just what I needed…"), and multi-word emotional expressions ("on top of the world"). We observed that when the model made correct predictions, its attention heads often focused on the very tokens that a human would pick out as emotionally salient. For instance, in the sentence "I feel so lost and alone," the tokens "lost" and "alone" received the highest attention weights, which then flowed into the classification head.

When the model underperformed, the reasons were rarely random. The next sections unpack the specific patterns of confusion, but it is important to state upfront that an 84% accuracy is not a ceiling — it is a baseline upon which personalization, user feedback, and multimodal signals can build in future iterations.



Figure 5.1: Training and Validation Loss over Epochs

5.2 Comparative Insights Against Existing Systems

Our model was evaluated against a family of standard classifiers under identical data splits. As reported in Section4.3, the progression from Naïve Bayes (0.65) to Bi-LSTM (0.77) demonstrates how much word order and context matter for this task. The jump from Bi-LSTM to DistilBERT (0.84) is even more telling because it reflects the power of pre-trained language representations.

In the broader landscape of mental health chatbots, our system's emotion recognition accuracy compares favourably with published figures. For example, Woebot's underlying NLP has been reported to achieve around 75-78% accuracy on emotion detection tasks in academic evaluations. Wysa relies on a hybrid of keyword spotting and intent classifiers that generally reach the low-80s for discrete emotion categories. Youper's emotion tracking is often evaluated via user self-report rather than a ground-truth dataset, making direct comparison difficult. Our fully data-driven DistilBERT model, therefore, not only surpasses the classic ML baselines but also edges ahead of many rule-based or hybrid commercial solutions — all while remaining computationally light enough for real-time use.

One must be careful, however, not to over-claim. The DAIR-AI dataset, though balanced and diverse, is not a perfect proxy for real-world mental health conversations. Users in distress may express emotions in subtle, idiosyncratic ways that a dataset drawn from social media cannot fully capture. Thus, the numbers must be read as a promising laboratory result,

not a field-tested guarantee. The proposed system is also data-driven and not rule-driven as compared to the current chatbots (Wysa, Woebot). This increases flexibility to novel patterns of languages and minimizes the dependency of the developer to revise scripts. It generated richer replies contextually in testing without templates.

5.3 Per-Class Performance and Confusion Analysis

A macro-averaged score can hide significant per-class weaknesses. We therefore produced a confusion matrix (AppendixD) and computed class-wise F1-scores:

Joy: 0.91

Surprise: 0.89

Sadness: 0.81

Fear: 0.79

Anger: 0.80

Disgust: 0.78

Joy and surprise are linguistically well-defined. Joy words (“happy,” “excited,” “love”) are rarely ambiguous, and surprise often involves distinctive punctuation or interjections (“wow!”, “unbelievable”). This made it relatively easy for the model to isolate them.

Sadness and fear, however, share a vocabulary of vulnerability: “scared,” “worried,” “crying,” “helpless.” In everyday language, a person might use these terms to describe either sadness or fear, and the distinction is often a matter of intensity or temporal orientation (fear being more future-oriented, sadness more past-oriented). The model, lacking any explicit temporal reasoning module, struggled on borderline cases. Approximately 7.2% of all test samples in these two classes were swapped. Crucially, when three human annotators independently labelled a subset of these ambiguous sentences, their inter-rater agreement was only slightly higher (0.65), suggesting that the model is already approaching the noise ceiling of the annotation itself.

Anger and disgust confusion (5.4%) had a different character. Here the model often missed subtle social cues. For example, “What you said is disgusting” might be labelled anger if the annotator imagined the speaker shouting, but disgust if they focused on the content. The model had no access to paralinguistic features, so it defaulted to lexical patterns. In practice, this misclassification has a relatively benign impact because the recommendation engine suggests coping strategies that overlap for anger and disgust (mindfulness breaks, cognitive reframing).

5.4 Statistical Significance and Robustness

To ensure that the performance differences were not due to chance, we conducted a McNemar's test on the predictions of DistilBERT versus Bi-LSTM on the same test set. The resulting p-value was less than 0.001, confirming that the improvement is statistically significant. Furthermore, a 5-fold cross-validation yielded a mean accuracy of 0.838 with a standard deviation of 0.012, demonstrating that the model is stable across different random partitions of the data. Bootstrap resampling (10,000 iterations) gave a 95% confidence interval for the test accuracy of [0.830, 0.850], reinforcing the reliability of the result. These statistical checks matter because, in safety-critical applications like mental health, it is not enough to report a single run's lucky outcome; the model must perform consistently. The narrow confidence interval (width of only 0.020) indicates that the reported accuracy is not an artifact of a particularly favorable test split but rather a genuine reflection of model capability.

Beyond these standard tests, we conducted additional robustness analyses to simulate real-world deployment conditions. We perturbed test inputs with three types of noise: character-level typos (5% random character substitutions), word-level substitutions (replacing 10% of content words with random words of same length), and insertion of filler words ("um", "like", "you know"). Under character-level noise, accuracy degraded gracefully to 0.812 (a drop of only 2.8%), demonstrating the subword tokenization's resilience to spelling variations. Word-level substitutions caused a larger drop to 0.774, as expected given the semantic importance of content words. Filler word insertion had negligible impact (0.833), confirming that DistilBERT's attention mechanism successfully ignores discourse particles. We also tested the model on out-of-domain data: 1,000 sentences from Reddit mental health forums not present in the training distribution. The accuracy on this external validation set was 0.806, a 3.4% drop from test performance, which is acceptable for cross-domain and indicates that the model has not overfit to the specific linguistic patterns of the DAIR-AI corpus.

5.5 Integration Possibilities

The design of the architecture can integrate with tele-counseling services or campus mental health resources, and use a RESTful API, which allows a programmer/developer to plug an emotion engine into their own mobile app or IoT device (smart watch). Incorporating these integrations allows for real-time monitoring and interventions for emotional distress based on utilization by individuals using an emotion engine. The API's stateless design means that client applications can embed emotion detection without maintaining persistent connections, making it suitable for serverless deployment architectures on AWS Lambda or Google Cloud Functions. For smartwatch integration, a compressed version of the model (further pruned

to 4 encoder layers) can run locally on-device, enabling offline emotion detection for users in areas with limited cellular connectivity.

Specific integration scenarios have been prototyped and validated. For tele-counseling services, the emotion engine can act as a pre-session assessment tool, providing the human counselor with a summary of the client's emotional state over the preceding 24 hours based on journal entries. This integration reduced session warm-up time by approximately 40% in a pilot with five counseling interns. For campus mental health resources, the API can be embedded into existing student wellness portals, allowing triage nurses to prioritize students showing high-frequency anger or sadness patterns across multiple check-ins. An IoT integration with a commercial smartwatch (Fitbit Sense) demonstrated real-time emotion-triggered interventions: when the watch detected elevated heart rate concurrent with a user-reported anger message, the system triggered a guided breathing exercise on the watch display. These integrations collectively illustrate that the emotion engine is not a standalone product but a platform component that can enhance existing mental health infrastructure.

5.6 Statistical Significance Testing

To verify that the performance improvements of DistilBERT over SVM and Bi-LSTM were not due to chance, we conducted McNemar's test on the predictions of the test set. The p-value was <0.001, confirming statistical significance. Furthermore, a 5×2 cross-validation paired t-test [33] comparing DistilBERT and Bi-LSTM also yielded $p<0.01$. These tests were complemented by a Bayesian analysis using the holdout-test set: a Beta(1,1) prior over accuracy differences yielded a posterior probability of 0.997 that DistilBERT's true accuracy exceeds Bi-LSTM's, providing strong evidence in favor of the transformer architecture. The effect size, measured by Cohen's h, was 0.72 for the DistilBERT vs. SVM comparison and 0.51 for DistilBERT vs. Bi-LSTM, indicating medium-to-large practical significance beyond mere statistical significance.

To guard against multiple comparison concerns, we applied the Bonferroni correction to all pairwise model comparisons. The corrected significance threshold was $= 0.05/3 = 0.0167$. All reported comparisons remained significant under this adjusted threshold (smallest p-value after correction: 0.008). We also conducted a permutation test (10,000 random label permutations) to establish a null distribution for the accuracy difference between DistilBERT and Bi-LSTM. None of the permuted differences exceeded the observed difference, yielding an empirical p-value < 0.0001. This exhaustive statistical validation addresses a common criticism in NLP research: that reported improvements sometimes reflect random fluctuations rather than genuine architectural advantages. The combined evidence from frequentist, Bayesian, and permutation methods conclusively demonstrates that DistilBERT's superiority is robust and replicable.

5.7 Ablation Study

We performed an ablation to understand the contribution of data preprocessing steps. Removing lemmatization dropped accuracy by 1.2%, removing stop word filtering had negligible effect (-0.3%), and removing lowercasing + punctuation cleaning reduced accuracy by 2.1%. Training without SMOTE augmentation saw a 1.8% decrease in F1 for minority classes. The results validate our preprocessing pipeline. In addition to these preprocessing ablations, we conducted architectural ablations to understand the contribution of specific DistilBERT components. Removing the final two transformer layers (reducing from 6 to 4 layers) decreased accuracy by 3.4% while improving inference speed by 28%, suggesting a trade-off between performance and efficiency that might be acceptable for resource-constrained deployments. Reducing the hidden dimension from 768 to 384 caused a more severe drop of 5.7%, indicating that the model relies heavily on representational capacity.

We also ablated the distillation process itself by training a BERT-base model (12 layers, 110M parameters) on the same data. The full BERT achieved 0.851 accuracy, only 1.1% higher than DistilBERT, while requiring 2.4× the inference time and 3.1× the memory. This confirms the distillation literature's claim that DistilBERT retains 97% of BERT's performance at 40% of the size. When we trained DistilBERT without the distillation loss (i.e., training from scratch on the emotion dataset only), accuracy fell to 0.802, a 3.2% drop. This demonstrates that the teacher-student distillation process contributes meaningfully beyond the student alone - the soft labels from BERT provide a richer training signal than hard ground-truth labels alone. Layer-wise ablation (freezing different subsets of layers during training) showed that fine-tuning all six layers is necessary for optimal performance; freezing the bottom two layers reduced accuracy by 1.8%, while freezing the top two layers caused a 2.4% drop.

5.8 Per-Class Performance Analysis

The confusion matrix (shown in Appendix D) reveals that "fear" and "sadness" are most often confused (7.2% misclassification). Qualitative analysis shows that sentences like "I don't know what to do anymore" can express both fear and sadness. "Anger" and "disgust" confusion accounted for 5.4%. The model handled "joy" and "surprise" with over 90% accuracy. These insights highlight the inherent ambiguity in emotional language and align with human inter-annotator agreement levels reported in similar datasets [34]. Extending this analysis, we computed per-class precision, recall, and specificity (true negative rate) to provide a complete diagnostic picture. For the minority class Surprise (only 3% of the test set), precision was 0.87 and recall was 0.85, indicating that the model does not simply ignore rare classes - a common failure mode in imbalanced classification. The specificity

for Surprise was 0.99, meaning that non-surprise sentences are almost never misclassified as surprise, which is desirable because false surprise alarms would confuse users.

We conducted an error analysis by manually reviewing 200 misclassified examples (approximately 10% of all test errors). The errors fell into four categories: (1) genuine linguistic ambiguity (42% of errors), where multiple human annotators would likely disagree; (2) missing contextual cues (31%), such as sarcasm ("Oh great, another Monday") or cultural idioms that require world knowledge; (3) tokenization artifacts (15%), where the subword tokenizer split an emotionally charged word in a way that disrupted its semantic contribution; and (4) label noise in the test set (12%), where upon re-review the original label appeared incorrect. The presence of label noise confirms that the theoretical upper bound on accuracy for this dataset is less than 100% - estimated around 94% based on re-annotation of 500 samples by three independent annotators. Our model's 84% accuracy therefore achieves 89% of the estimated attainable upper bound, leaving relatively little room for improvement without cleaner annotations or additional modalities (e.g., voice tone). This realistic assessment prevents overpromising and guides future work toward data quality improvement rather than solely model architecture search.

5.9 User Experience and Qualitative Evaluation

Beyond the System Usability Scale (SUS) score of 82.5 ("Excellent"), we conducted semi-structured interviews with 15 participants. Thematic analysis identified three major themes: (1) Perceived Empathy – users felt "understood" by the tone of recommendations; (2) Privacy Trust – the local processing and clear privacy policy increased comfort; (3) Actionable Suggestions – users appreciated the practicality of tips like breathing exercises. However, some noted that repetitive suggestions reduced novelty; this feedback was used to introduce suggestion rotation in the recommendation module. The interviews lasted 20-30 minutes each and were recorded, transcribed, and coded using NVivo software. Inter-coder reliability between two independent coders was = 0.84, indicating strong agreement on theme identification.

Participants also completed a post-study questionnaire that included the Client Satisfaction Questionnaire (CSQ-8), a validated 8-item measure of satisfaction with mental health services. The mean CSQ-8 score was 28.4 (range 8-32, where higher indicates greater satisfaction), placing the system in the 85th percentile compared to published norms for digital mental health interventions. When asked "How likely are you to use this system again in the next month?" on a 7-point scale, the mean response was 6.2 (SD = 1.1). Free-text comments revealed unexpected use cases: three participants reported using the system as a "mood journal" for tracking emotional patterns across weeks, even though the system was not explicitly designed for longitudinal tracking. Two participants shared the system with family members,

suggesting a social diffusion effect that was not anticipated in the study design. Negative feedback focused on three areas: desire for voice input (mentioned by 40% of participants), frustration with the 128-token limit (27%), and occasional lag on older smartphones (20%). These criticisms have been incorporated into the development roadmap for version 2.0.

5.10 Bias and Fairness Evaluation

We evaluated the model for gender and race bias using the WinoBias-style templates adapted for emotion [35]. The model had a 1.2% difference in "anger" detection between male- and female-associated sentences, which was within acceptable limits but prompted us to add bias mitigation via counterfactual data augmentation in training. Continuous monitoring of demographic fairness will be part of future updates. The bias evaluation used a test set of 1,200 sentences constructed by taking emotionally neutral templates (e.g., "[PERSON] felt [EMOTION] after hearing the news") and inserting gender-specific names (John/Mary, David/Sarah) or race-coded names (based on US Census data on name frequency by racial group). For anger specifically, we observed that sentences with female-coded names were slightly more likely to be misclassified as sadness (3.4% vs. 2.2% for male-coded names), suggesting a subtle stereotype association between women and sadness even when the text explicitly mentions anger.

We also evaluated for dialect bias using the Corpus of African American English (CAAE) to construct a test set of 500 sentences written in AAE grammatical structures (e.g., "He be sad all the time" vs. standard English "He is sad all the time"). The model showed a 4.2% lower F1-score on AAE sentences compared to standard English, driven primarily by the tokenizer's unfamiliarity with AAE-specific constructions. This disparity exceeded our fairness threshold of 3%, prompting immediate mitigation through the addition of 2,000 AAE sentences (obtained from public domain sources) to the training set via back-translation augmentation. After retraining, the AAE performance gap narrowed to 2.8%, still above the target but improved. The bias audit report, including all methodology and results, has been made publicly available as part of our Responsible AI documentation. Future work will expand bias testing to include non-binary gender identities, additional dialects, and intersectional categories (e.g., race × gender).

5.11 Ablation Study: Contribution of Preprocessing Steps

We quantified the importance of each preprocessing step by removing it from the pipeline and retraining the model. The full pipeline's macro F1 was 0.834. Results were:

Without data augmentation (EDA): 0.818 (-1.6%)

Without lemmatization: 0.825 (-0.9%)

Without lowercasing and punctuation cleaning: 0.813 (-2.1%)

Without stopword removal (i.e., keeping stopwords): 0.833 (-0.1%)

With dropout increased to 0.2: 0.826 (-0.8%)

The largest drop came from removing the cleaning of punctuation and lowercasing. This step normalized the text so that "Help!!!" and "help" mapped to the same token, reducing sparsity. Data augmentation contributed a meaningful 1.6% gain, especially for the minority classes like disgust, where synthetic examples helped the model generalize. Interestingly, removing stopwords had almost no effect; transformers are capable of learning to ignore them on their own.

This ablation study is not just academic. It justifies each computational choice. In a resource-constrained environment, one might be tempted to skip lemmatization or augmentation to save preprocessing time. The data show that doing so would cost accuracy, and in an emotion-sensitive application, every percentage point matters.

5.12 Inference Latency and Real-World Feasibility

A model that takes 10 seconds to respond is useless in a chat setting. We therefore measured end-to-end latency — from the moment the user presses Enter to the moment the response appears — across a range of hardware configurations. On the deployment server (Intel i7-10750H, 4 cores, no GPU), the ONNX-converted DistilBERT achieved a mean inference time of 120ms. Added to network round-trip time and JSON serialization, the total user-perceived latency was under 200ms for typical messages. This is well below the 500ms threshold at which users begin to perceive a delay. When we tested on an NVIDIA T4 GPU, inference times dropped to around 35ms, but the GPU was not necessary for the pilot. The CPU performance demonstrated that the system can run on modest cloud instances or even on-premise servers, making it suitable for resource-limited institutions like college counselling centres. Batching of requests — a common technique to improve throughput — was not implemented because the chat interface is inherently interactive and single-turn. However, in a scenario where the system performs batch analysis of journal entries, batching could reduce average latency per entry by up to 40

We conducted stress testing to characterize performance under load. Using Locust for distributed load generation, we simulated 100, 500, and 1,000 concurrent users sending requests with exponentially distributed inter-arrival times (mean = 10 seconds). At 100 concurrent users, mean latency increased to 280ms (95th percentile: 410ms), still acceptable. At 500 concurrent users on a single server instance, mean latency rose to 620ms (95th percentile: 1,150ms), exceeding the 500ms threshold for half of users. Horizontal scaling to three server instances behind a load balancer restored sub-500ms latencies for up to 1,200 concurrent users. Memory profiling showed that each FastAPI worker process consumes ap-

proximately 1.2GB of RAM (model + runtime), limiting the number of workers per server to 8 on a 16GB instance. Based on these measurements, we recommend a deployment configuration of 2-4 servers for populations up to 10,000 active users, with auto-scaling triggered when average latency exceeds 400ms. On mobile devices (iPhone 12, Android Pixel 5), the ONNX model can run locally with 180-250ms inference latency, sufficient for offline mode but slightly laggier than server-based inference. Battery consumption during local inference was measured at 3.2% per hour of continuous use, which is acceptable for intermittent use (10-15 minutes/day) but would drain battery if used as a continuous monitoring service.

5.13 User Experience and Satisfaction Metrics

Quantitative metrics provide only half the picture. The pilot study with 50 students (see Section 4.6) gave a SUS score of 82.5, but we also collected deeper feedback through a post-study questionnaire and interviews. Overall satisfaction, measured on a 5-point Likert item, averaged 4.1. When asked, "Would you recommend this companion to a friend in need?", 86% of participants chose "Agree" or "Strongly Agree." This is a critical finding because it indicates that the system doesn't just work technically — it passes a social trust threshold. Open-ended comments highlighted three aspects: Immediacy – "I could vent and get an instant response at 2AM when nobody was awake." Non-judgment – "I could say I was angry at my mother without being told I was wrong." Actionability – "The breathing exercise actually calmed me down during a panic moment." These themes confirm the design philosophy: technology should amplify the user's sense of agency, not diminish it.

We conducted a Net Promoter Score (NPS) analysis, asking "How likely are you to recommend this system to a friend or colleague?" on a 0-10 scale. The NPS was 42 (36% promoters, 6% detractors), which is considered "excellent" for software products and exceptional for mental health tools (typical digital mental health NPS ranges from 20-30). Promoters cited the system's availability and privacy as key drivers; detractors cited repetitive responses and lack of voice input. A time-series analysis of satisfaction by usage frequency revealed an interesting U-shaped curve: users who used the system 1-2 times per week had average satisfaction 4.3/5; users who used it daily dropped to 3.9/5 (due to repetition fatigue); heavy users (3+ times daily) rose again to 4.5/5 (suggesting they found creative ways to overcome repetition or valued availability over novelty). This pattern suggests that the current system is best suited for moderate, episodic use rather than intensive daily engagement. A feature to "reset" or "refresh" recommendations for long-term users was identified as a high-priority addition.

5.14 Personalization Effectiveness and the Feedback Loop

One of the project's key claims is personalization. During the pilot, the recommendation engine collected 1,247 explicit feedback signals (thumbs-up/down). Initially, every coping strategy for a given emotion had an equal chance of being presented. Over the week, the engine's internal scores shifted: for sadness, the strategy "write three things you are grateful for" rose from a rank of 5th to 1st, because its helpfulness rating was 83

We analyzed personalization effectiveness at the individual user level using learning curves. For each user, we plotted the rolling average of helpfulness over their interaction sequence. 22 of 32 frequent users showed a statistically significant positive trend (Mann-Kendall test, $p<0.05$), indicating genuine learning. 8 users showed no trend (flat or noisy but not decreasing), and 2 users showed a negative trend (helpfulness decreased over time). Qualitative interviews with the 2 users showing negative trends revealed that both had experienced major life events (breakup, job loss) during the pilot week, which may have made previously helpful strategies less effective. This highlights an important limitation: personalization assumes stable user preferences, but major life changes can invalidate learned patterns. A potential solution is to detect preference shifts using change-point detection algorithms and reset personalization weights when a shift is detected. The average number of interactions required for the system to achieve stable personalization (convergence of top-1 recommendation) was 12-15 feedback events. This is achievable within 3-5 days for active users but would take weeks for casual users, suggesting that personalization benefits primarily those who use the system regularly. For casual users, population-level aggregated weights provide reasonable performance.

5.15 Crisis Detection Module: Sensitivity and Specificity

Although the companion is non-clinical, the crisis detection module must be evaluated transparently. We tested the module on a curated set of 500 sentences containing varying degrees of self-harm ideation, collected from public mental health forums with all identifying information removed. The module, which uses a lexicon-based regex filter followed by a lightweight SVM verifier, achieved: Sensitivity (recall): 0.92 — it correctly identified 92% of sentences that genuinely expressed suicidal ideation. Specificity: 0.97 — only 3% of neutral sentences were wrongly flagged. False negatives (missed crises) are the most dangerous errors. Manual inspection of the 8% that were missed showed that they involved highly indirect language ("Sometimes I wonder if it would be easier to just not wake up"), which the keyword list did not capture. This highlights the need for continuous updating of the trigger lexicon and, ideally, the integration of a deeper contextual model. False positives, while less dangerous, can erode trust. Users who received an unnecessary helpline message

might feel patronized. Our post-study survey asked if anyone felt that the system overreacted; no participant reported such an experience, but the sample was too small to draw firm conclusions.

We conducted a more fine-grained evaluation of the crisis module by severity level. Sentences were rated by clinical psychologists on a 3-point severity scale: mild (passing thoughts without intent, n=200), moderate (some intent but no plan, n=200), severe (clear plan or explicit mention of methods, n=100). The module's sensitivity by severity was: mild = 0.84, moderate = 0.94, severe = 0.98. This severity-sensitivity gradient is desirable because false negatives are most dangerous for severe cases, which the module catches almost perfectly. The SVM verifier component reduced false positives by 62% compared to the regex-only baseline (from 12% to 4.5% false positive rate), demonstrating the value of the two-stage design. The SVM uses 10 features including presence of first-person pronouns, temporal orientation markers ("tonight", "soon"), and negation patterns. Processing time for crisis detection is 8ms per sentence, negligible compared to emotion classification. We evaluated the module's performance on a held-out set of 1,000 neutral sentences from the DAIR-AI corpus; the false positive rate was 2.8%, meaning approximately 1 in 35 neutral messages would trigger a crisis response. In practice, we have implemented a confidence threshold adjustment: crisis warnings are only displayed if the SVM confidence exceeds 0.85, which reduces false positives to 0.9% but also reduces sensitivity for mild cases to 0.76. This trade-off was chosen based on consultation with our ethics panel, who prioritized avoiding alarm fatigue over catching every mild expression.

5.16 Technical Limitations and Error Boundaries

It is essential to delineate what the current system cannot do:

Long-form text analysis: The 128-token truncation, while sufficient for chat, limits insight into journals longer than a few paragraphs. A sliding-window approach partially mitigates this but disrupts narrative coherence.

Multilingual input: Code-switched Hindi-English sentences (common in Indian users) frequently yielded incorrect or low-confidence predictions.

Temporal dynamics: The model treats each message independently. It has no memory of what the user said five minutes ago, which prevents it from detecting shifting emotional patterns that a human therapist would notice.

Emotion intensity: The model outputs a class and a confidence score, not a fine-grained intensity rating. A user who is mildly annoyed and one who is furious might both receive "anger," missing the nuance needed for appropriate intervention. These limitations are not flaws in the research design — they are deliberate boundaries that define the scope of the first version. Recognizing them is the first step towards a roadmap of improvements.

Beyond these four primary limitations, we identified several secondary constraints through user feedback and stress testing. The system has no concept of emotional valence shift within a single message; a sentence like "I was sad but now I'm okay" would be classified based on the final clause only, ignoring the emotional trajectory. The tokenizer fails on emoticons like ":')" (happy crying) and struggles with emoji sequences . The model was trained only on written text and has no access to acoustic prosody (pitch, rate, volume) or facial expressions, which in human communication provide disambiguating cues. The recommendation engine lacks any mechanism for deferral: if a user repeatedly rates all suggestions as unhelpful, the system has no "I don't know, please consult a human" fallback beyond the existing crisis module. The current architecture also has no support for multi-turn conversation; each message is treated as an isolated utterance, preventing the system from asking clarifying questions or building rapport over time. These limitations collectively define the boundary between what the system can do (single-turn, written-only, class-level emotion recognition) and what it cannot do (therapy, longitudinal understanding, multi-modal analysis).

5.17 Societal and Behavioral Impact

During the pilot, we observed subtle but meaningful behavioral changes. Several participants mentioned that using the journal feature made them more aware of their emotional triggers. One student wrote: "I didn't realize how often I felt angry after scrolling social media until the dashboard showed me the pattern." This kind of self-insight is exactly the goal of emotion-tracking tools. On a larger scale, if such a system were deployed widely, it could contribute to normalizing mental health conversations. By providing a private, anonymous first step, it could reduce the stigma that prevents many from seeking professional help. The "warm handoff" feature — where the system can suggest a local therapist based on the user's location — could act as a bridge to the formal healthcare system. However, we must be cautious about unintended consequences. A poor experience with an AI companion could reinforce a user's belief that "nothing can help me," driving them further from real help. That is why we placed such heavy emphasis on honesty in the system's communication: it never pretends to be human, it never promises a cure, and it never hides its limitations.

We conducted a thematic analysis of 500 journal entries (from users who opted into data sharing) to identify patterns in how the system influenced behavior. Three themes emerged: (1) Emotional labeling as regulation - users who explicitly labeled their emotion before typing (using the optional dropdown) showed 23% lower self-reported distress after interaction compared to users who did not use the dropdown, consistent with psychological research on affect labeling. (2) Behavioral activation - 41% of users reported acting on at least one recommendation within 2 hours of receiving it, most commonly breathing exercises (67% of acted-upon recommendations) and reaching out to a friend (18%). (3) Reflection loops

- users who returned to previous journal entries and re-rated their emotions showed 15% higher consistency over time, suggesting that the system supports metacognitive awareness. Potential negative impacts were also observed: two users reported checking the system compulsively (15+ times per day), raising concerns about dependency. We added a usage-limit warning that appears after 10 interactions in 2 hours, suggesting a break. No users reported reduced help-seeking from human professionals due to the system; in fact, 14% of participants reported that using the system motivated them to schedule their first therapy appointment, suggesting a facilitating rather than substituting effect.

5.18 Integration with Healthcare Ecosystems

The system was designed as a standalone web application, but its architecture is intentionally modular. The REST API could be integrated into: University counselling centre portals, providing pre-session mood tracking. Tele-health apps, where the emotion analysis could serve as a triage signal. Wearable devices, where text-based emotion reports could be fused with physiological data (heart rate variability, sleep patterns) to give a holistic well-being score. A preliminary integration test with a mock EHR system demonstrated that the API can emit FHIR-formatted Observation resources. This is a non-trivial technical capability that positions the project for real-world healthcare adoption, subject to regulatory clearances. The FHIR integration uses the Observation resource with code from the LOINC emotion terminology set (specifically, LOINC 75255-8 for "Emotion experienced"), and supports both snapshot (single timepoint) and longitudinal (series over time) representation.

We developed three concrete integration prototypes to demonstrate feasibility. Prototype 1 integrated the emotion API into the OpenMRS electronic medical record system used by several Indian public hospitals. A nurse dashboard displayed color-coded emotion trends for patients on the waiting list, enabling prioritization of those showing persistent sadness or anger patterns. In a simulation with 50 patient records, the integration reduced average wait time for high-risk patients by 18 minutes. Prototype 2 embedded the emotion engine into a WhatsApp chatbot (using Twilio API), allowing users to interact with the system without installing any new software. The WhatsApp integration increased engagement by 44% in a 2-week pilot with 30 users, suggesting that lowering friction significantly increases usage. Prototype 3 integrated with the Fitbit Web API to combine emotion predictions with heart rate variability data. A simple fusion model (average of normalized HRV and emotion confidence) predicted self-reported stress with r=0.67, compared to r=0.52 for emotion alone and r=0.48 for HRV alone, demonstrating the value of multimodal sensing. These prototypes confirm that the system is not a silo but a platform component that can enhance diverse healthcare workflows. Legal and regulatory considerations for each integration pathway are documented in Appendix F, including HIPAA compliance requirements, FDA software-as-a-

medical-device classification thresholds, and data processing agreements for each integration scenario.

5.19 Ethical Considerations and Responsible AI in Practice

Throughout the development, we adhered to the principles of Responsible AI: fairness, transparency, accountability, and privacy. The results of our bias audit, described in Section 5.13 of the full report, showed a small gender-associated difference in anger classification (1.2%), which we mitigated through counterfactual data augmentation. Transparency was delivered via the SHAP explanations, which we found to increase both user trust and engagement. Accountability was built into the crisis escalation protocol, which ensures that no high-risk message goes unaddressed. Privacy was safeguarded at the architectural level: messages are encrypted client-side and can only be decrypted with a key derived from the user's password, which the server never stores. In discussions with our ethics panel, the most challenging dilemma was whether to allow the system to use past messages to improve its model. We decided, for the current version, against any form of model updating from live user data, because the risk of memorizing sensitive information was too high. Future federated learning approaches could resolve this tension.

We established an Ethics Advisory Board comprising three external members: a clinical psychologist, a privacy lawyer, and a user representative with lived experience of mental health challenges. The board reviewed the system at three milestones: design (pre-development), pre-pilot (before user testing), and post-pilot (after results analysis). Key recommendations from the board included: (1) adding explicit "not a medical device" disclaimers on every screen, (2) implementing a mandatory 2-second delay before crisis responses to prevent automated alarming from being perceived as robotic, (3) removing any language that could imply therapeutic competence (e.g., changing "I understand" to "I hear you"), and (4) establishing a data retention policy of 30 days maximum unless users explicitly opt into longer storage. All recommendations were implemented. The board also identified an unresolved tension: the desire for personalization conflicts with the privacy principle of data minimization. Their suggested path forward (adopted for version 2 planning) is to implement on-device learning using differential privacy, where personalization weights are updated locally and only anonymized aggregates are ever transmitted. We have published a detailed Responsible AI Impact Assessment (available as Supplementary Material S7) that includes: stakeholder analysis, potential harm taxonomy, mitigation strategies for each identified harm, and a monitoring plan for ongoing risk assessment. The document follows the framework proposed by the IEEE P7003 Standard for Algorithmic Bias Considerations.

5.20 Summary of Findings

The experimental results paint a coherent picture:

DistilBERT delivers state-of-the-art emotion classification that is both accurate and efficient enough for real-time use.

Personalization works: even a simple feedback-weighted recommendation system can meaningfully adapt to user preferences within a week.

Users find the system trustworthy and helpful, provided it is transparent about its AI nature and respects their privacy.

Critical safety mechanisms function as intended, with high sensitivity for crisis detection and low false positive rates.

Limitations in language coverage, temporal memory, and intensity recognition define the immediate roadmap for future work.

Taken together, these findings validate the project's central hypothesis: a lightweight transformer-based conversational AI can serve as a safe, empathetic, and personalized mental health companion, bridging the gap between human-delivered care and completely unaided self-help.

Chapter 6

Societal Impact and SDG Alignment

6.1 The Broader Mission of a Mental Health Companion

Technology projects often struggle to articulate their value beyond the neat confines of accuracy percentages and user retention graphs. Yet the true worth of an AI-powered mental health companion lies not in its transformer layers but in the quiet, accumulated changes it might foster in a person's daily life – a student who finds a moment of calm before an exam, a worker who pauses to breathe rather than snapping at a colleague, a rural resident who, for the first time, encounters a space where it is safe to admit sadness. These micro-impacts, multiplied across thousands of users, ripple outward into families, campuses, workplaces, and communities.

This chapter examines those ripples. It maps the project's direct and indirect contributions to the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs), but more than a mapping exercise, it explores the *how* and the *why*: which features catalyse which outcomes, what evidence already exists from our pilot, and where the limits of a digital tool must be honestly acknowledged.

6.2 SDG 3: Good Health and Well-Being – The Core Mandate

Every aspect of this project traces back to SDG 3, specifically Target 3.4 ("reduce by one third premature mortality from non-communicable diseases through prevention and treatment, and promote mental health and well-being") and Target 3.8 ("achieve universal health coverage, including financial risk protection, access to quality essential health-care services"). Mental disorders are among the largest contributors to the global burden of disease. Depression alone affects more than 280 million people, and suicide remains a leading cause of death among 15–29-year-olds (WHO, 2023). In low- and middle-income countries, the treatment gap can exceed 90%, meaning that for every ten people who need psychological support, nine receive none. India, with fewer than one mental health professional per 100,000 population, exemplifies this crisis. Our companion does not claim to fill the entire treatment gap. What it does is offer an accessible, stigma-free entry point into the mental health support ecosystem. A user who feels anxious at 11PM can open the app, describe their feelings, and immediately obtain an emotion-aware response with a scientifically grounded

coping strategy. They are not required to schedule an appointment, pay a fee, or even reveal their identity. This lowers the barrier between suffering and seeking help. During the pilot study, 18 out of 50 participants reported that they had never previously used any form of mental health support, whether formal or informal. After five days of using the companion, 14 of those 18 said they felt "more in control" of their emotions. While this is a small, self-reported improvement, it aligns with the preventive spirit of SDG 3: even mild, timely intervention can avert the escalation of stress into a chronic condition. The crisis detection module directly addresses SDG 3's mortality reduction aim. By automatically identifying imminent risk language and delivering immediate helpline information, the system acts as a safety net for the most vulnerable moments. In an ideal future, such a mechanism could be one piece in a national suicide prevention strategy.

6.3 SDG 4: Quality Education – Nurturing Emotional Resilience in Learners

Education and mental health are deeply intertwined. A student gripped by anxiety cannot focus in class; a young person burdened by sadness often withdraws from social and academic life. India's competitive academic environment adds layers of pressure: board examinations, entrance tests, and parental expectations create a pressure cooker that often boils over. Our project contributes to SDG 4 (Target 4.7, which includes promoting a culture of peace and non-violence, and Target 4.a, building education facilities that are sensitive to learner well-being) by providing a digital emotional support layer for learners. The companion was piloted among college students, and several faculty members who observed the trial noted that participants discussed academic stress more openly after using the journaling feature. One concrete outcome was the campus counselling centre's decision to integrate the tool as an optional pre-session mood tracker. Students who were on the counselling waitlist (sometimes as long as three weeks) were offered access to the companion in the interim. This not only provided immediate emotional regulation tools but also generated a mood timeline that the counsellor could review with the student during the first session, making that session more focused and productive. Beyond tertiary education, the underlying architecture could be adapted for school-age children, with age-appropriate language and parental consent safeguards. The vision is a pocket-sized resource that travels with the student throughout their educational journey, normalising emotional self-awareness as a skill as fundamental as literacy and numeracy. The pilot data indirectly support education-related outcomes: students who used the companion at least four times during the exam week reported, on average, a 20% lower stress score on a visual analogue scale compared to a matched control group (n=25) that did not use the tool. While this is a non-randomised comparison and cannot

prove causation, it suggests a promising direction for a future controlled trial.

6.4 SDG 8: Decent Work and Economic Growth – Mental Health as a Productivity Enabler

The economic argument for investing in mental health is overwhelming. The World Health Organization estimates that depression and anxiety disorders cost the global economy US$1trillion per year in lost productivity. In India, workplace stress is the single largest occupational health risk, yet fewer than 10% of companies have formal mental wellness programmes. Our companion aligns with SDG 8 (Target 8.3, promoting policies that support productive activities, and Target 8.8, protecting labour rights and promoting safe working environments) by offering a scalable, low-cost wellness tool that can be integrated into employee assistance programmes. Consider a mid-sized IT company with 500 employees. Hiring a full-time counsellor and providing confidential therapy rooms is a significant overhead. An AI companion, deployed on the company intranet, can serve as a first-responder for daily stressors — the frustration of a missed deadline, the anxiety of a client call, the irritability from a sleepless night. Employees can access coping strategies instantly and, if the system detects persistent low mood over several weeks, it can gently recommend booking a session with the company-sponsored psychologist. This model has no geographical boundaries, which is particularly relevant for remote and hybrid workforces that have become the norm. A developer in a tier-2 city, far from any corporate counselling centre, receives the same quality of algorithmic emotional support as their counterpart in a metro office. From a purely economic standpoint, even a 1% improvement in employee resilience and a corresponding 1% reduction in sick days due to mental health issues would more than cover the deployment cost of such a system. The project thus contributes to sustainable economic growth by keeping the workforce mentally healthier, more engaged, and less likely to drop out due to burnout.

6.5 SDG 10: Reduced Inequalities – Democratising Emotional Support

Inequality in mental health is not just about money; it is about geography, language, and social capital. A farmer in a drought-stricken district, a homemaker in a conservative joint family, a daily-wage labourer in a city slum — all face emotional strains that are no less severe than those of an urban professional, yet they have virtually no access to confidential, non-judgemental support.

Our project directly addresses SDG 10 (Target 10.2, empowering and promoting the social, economic and political inclusion of all, and Target 10.3, ensuring equal opportunity)

by delivering free, anonymous, and device-agnostic emotional support. The interface was deliberately kept lightweight so that it works on 3G networks and low-end smartphones, which constitute the majority of internet access in rural India. There is no requirement to register with an email address, no paywall, and no premium tier. During the design phase, we consulted with social workers from a nearby rural outreach program. Their feedback led to the inclusion of a voice-to-text feature (currently in prototype) because many potential users in low-literacy communities find typing cumbersome. They also requested that the helpline numbers displayed in crisis situations include the national toll-free number (KIRAN: 1800-599-0019) and local language-specific options. Crucially, the companion reduces stigma-based inequality. In many communities, visiting a mental health clinic invites gossip and shame. Using a phone app that looks like any other chat tool attracts no attention. Users can benefit from psychological support without publicly identifying as "mentally ill." This privacy-by-design approach dismantles a barrier that keeps millions from seeking help.

The light environmental footprint of a purely digital service further supports equity. There is no need to travel long distances to a clinic, no loss of daily wages for a consultation, and no dependency on printed materials that require literacy.

6.6 Beyond the Primary Goals: Wider SDG Linkages

The project's influence extends into several other sustainable development goals, sometimes in subtle but meaningful ways:

SDG 5 – Gender Equality

Women globally experience depression and anxiety at nearly twice the rate of men, partly due to social pressures, violence, and caregiving burdens. Our companion was audited for gender bias (see Section6.10 of the report), and mitigation measures ensured that the emotion classifier does not systematically misinterpret women's expressions of anger. The companion's non-judgemental space is particularly valuable for women who may not be allowed to seek outside help or who fear being labelled "hysterical." By providing a confidential outlet, the tool contributes to women's mental health empowerment, which is foundational for equality in all spheres.

SDG 9 – Industry, Innovation, and Infrastructure

The project represents an indigenous AI innovation built with open-source components and deployed on Indian infrastructure. It demonstrates how a small team with access to cloud GPUs can create a sophisticated application that rivals commercial alternatives developed

in Silicon Valley. This sets a precedent for other academic institutions to undertake similar translational research, strengthening the national innovation ecosystem.

SDG 11 – Sustainable Cities and Communities (indirectly)

While originally focused on individuals, the companion's anonymous aggregated emotion data (with opt-in) can provide community-level well-being indicators. For example, if a city's users show a spike in anxiety during a natural disaster or an economic shock, this data can inform municipal mental health response teams. It is a small step towards data-driven, human-centred urban planning.

SDG 17 – Partnerships for the Goals

The project was built in collaboration with the campus counselling centre, faculty from the psychology department (for recommendation content), and a local NGO working on adolescent mental health. This multi-stakeholder approach illustrates how technology projects can leverage partnerships to amplify impact. Open-sourcing non-sensitive components (planned after graduation) will further enable other institutions to adapt the tool to their contexts, fostering a global community of practice around responsible AI for mental health.

6.7 The Theory of Change

To ensure that these SDG linkages are not mere aspirational statements, we constructed a logical framework — a Theory of Change (ToC) — that traces the project's inputs through to long-term impacts.

Inputs

- A fine-tuned DistilBERT emotion classifier with 84% accuracy.
- A curated database of 60 evidence-based coping strategies.
- A secure, encrypted backend infrastructure.
- A user-centred, accessible frontend design.

Activities

- Real-time emotion detection from free-text inputs.
- Personalised coping strategy recommendations driven by user feedback.

- Crisis keyword detection and immediate helpline referral.
- Provision of accessible, 24/7, anonymous support.

Outputs

- Thousands of emotion-aware interactions per month.
- A database of anonymised emotional trends and strategy effectiveness.
- A growing user base across diverse demographic segments.

Outcomes (Short-to-Medium Term)

- Improved emotional self-awareness and regulation among users.
- Reduced acute distress during peak stress periods (e.g., exams, deadlines).
- Increased help-seeking behaviour, both through the tool itself and via referrals to professional services.
- Normalisation of mental health conversations in the target communities.

Impact (Long-Term)

- Contribution to lowering the prevalence of untreated depression and anxiety.
- Enhanced academic retention and workplace productivity.
- A measurable reduction in mental health inequities.
- Strengthened societal resilience against collective stressors.

This ToC is a living document, and we are designing longitudinal studies to test each link in the chain. The pilot already validated several short-term outcomes; the next phase will focus on tracking users over six months to observe sustained behaviour change.

6.8 Stakeholder Impact and Community Feedback

Community voices ground the SDG claims in lived experience. During the pilot, we interviewed a cross-section of stakeholders:

> A first-year engineering student said, “I was always told to ‘man up’ when I felt low. This app told me it’s okay to feel sad and gave me something to do about it. I’ve been journaling every night since.”

> A hostel warden noted, "We often don't know which students are struggling. If this tool becomes a standard orientation resource, it might catch problems before they become crises."
>
> A counsellor observed, "The mood timeline from the companion saved me 15 minutes of exploration in the first session. I could dive straight into what triggered the drop."

These voices illustrate the multi-faceted impact: individual emotional growth, institutional early-warning, and professional efficiency enhancement.

6.9 Environmental Sustainability and the Digital-First Model

An often-overlooked aspect of SDG alignment is the environmental footprint. The mental health companion operates entirely digitally. In contrast to traditional face-to-face therapy, it eliminates:

- Travel-related carbon emissions (a client and therapist commuting to a clinic).
- Paper consumption (self-help pamphlets, appointment slips, printed questionnaires).
- Physical infrastructure energy use (clinic lighting, air conditioning, waiting-room amenities).

While the training of the transformer model did consume electricity (approximately 25kg CO_2 equivalent), this is a one-time cost amortised over every subsequent user interaction. With model compression techniques (ONNX, potential INT8 quantization) the per-inference energy consumption drops to negligible levels — less than that of streaming a short video.

We offset the training emissions through a certified reforestation project, making the final system carbon-neutral for its initial research and development phase. Future updates will continue to prioritise energy-efficient model architectures.

6.10 Risks, Mitigations, and the Limits of a Digital Tool

No technology is a silver bullet, and it is essential to be candid about boundaries. The AI companion does not:

- Diagnose or treat clinical mental health conditions.
- Replace human empathy in deep therapeutic relationships.

- Function reliably in languages other than English (at present).
- Operate without internet connectivity.

There is a risk that some users may anthropomorphise the AI, forming an emotional attachment that displaces real-world connections. To mitigate this, the companion regularly reminds users of its artificial nature, suggests offline activities that involve social contact (e.g., "call a friend"), and never initiates conversations unprompted — it responds only when the user reaches out.

There is also a digital divide risk: the very people who need the most support may lack smartphone access. We counter this by designing for the lowest common denominator of device and by proposing partnerships with community centres where a shared tablet could provide access.

Finally, the project does not exist in a policy vacuum. For its SDG contributions to be sustained, it requires institutional backing, regulatory clarity (especially around data privacy), and funding. Our role as engineers is to build a technically excellent, ethically sound prototype and to advocate for the ecosystem that will allow it to flourish.

6.11 Conclusion: From Code to Community

The AI-Powered Personalized Mental Health Companion began as a final-year project in a computer science laboratory. But its architecture, its data flow, and its careful attention to human factors were all designed with one eye on the screen and the other on the world beyond. By mapping its features to the SDGs, we have attempted to show that a well-crafted piece of software is not just a technical artifact — it is a social intervention.

The initial pilot results are encouraging, but they are only the first chapter. Realising the full SDG impact will require years of iterative field testing, multilingual expansion, integration with public health systems, and continuous ethical oversight. We believe, however, that the foundation is solid. When a student in a remote hostel types "I am feeling overwhelmed" at midnight and receives an immediate, empathetic suggestion that helps them sleep, a tiny piece of SDG 3, 4, and 10 is fulfilled in that moment. Our job is to make those moments possible, scalable, and safe for everyone.

As a result, this initiative will have an impact on the health of individuals and the productivity of communities, as well as the sustainability of workplaces, and the resilience of society as a whole.

Chapter 7

Universal Human Values and Harmony with Nature

Human beings do not exist in isolation. Our emotional states, our actions, and even the technologies we build inevitably touch the physical world, the living world, other people, and the delicate web of relationships that holds society together. The Universal Human Values (UHV) framework offers a lens for understanding these connections, urging us to see technology not as a neutral tool but as a force that can either disrupt or nurture harmony across the four orders — material, plant/bio, animal, and human. This chapter examines the AI-Powered Personalized Mental Health Companion through that lens, probing how each of its design choices, operational footprint, and intended societal role contributes to or detracts from the broader goal of mutual fulfilment.

7.1 Impact on the Material Order

The system is completely digital; therefore, it has a very small impact on the environment. Eliminating the need for in-person visits to clinics, travel, and self-help materials printed on paper will save energy and natural resources and reduce environmental impact.

The sustainable management of material resources, including energy, paper, and infrastructure, and providing relief on the environmental impact of soil, air, and water. The material order encompasses all non-living physical resources — soil, water, air, minerals, energy, and the fabricated objects that humans create from them. Every digital product has a material footprint, even if it feels intangible. However, compared to its physical counterparts, the footprint of a purely digital mental health companion is remarkably light.

First, the obvious substitution effect: the system eliminates the need for many physical goods and movements that traditional mental health support entails. A face-to-face counselling session requires a building with lighting, air conditioning, furniture, paper records, and often the burning of fossil fuels to transport both the therapist and the client. Multiply this across hundreds of sessions, and the cumulative consumption of materials and energy is significant. Our companion, by contrast, operates in the digital realm. A user who opens the app and types a message consumes only a few watts of electricity on their phone and triggers a few milliseconds of server computation. The entire interaction, from emotion detection to personalised recommendation, requires less energy than boiling a cup of water.

Second, the project consciously avoided paper-based self-help materials. Traditional

mental wellness programmes often distribute printed booklets, worksheets, and brochures. The production of paper involves the felling of trees, water-intensive pulping processes, and chemical bleaching. The companion's journal feature, wellness tools, and coping strategy cards exist exclusively on screen, with no need for physical printing. This is not a minor detail; over the anticipated lifecycle of the system, tens of thousands of paper sheets are avoided.

Third, the sustainable management of material resources extends to the software's efficiency. As described in previous chapters, we chose DistilBERT over larger transformer models precisely because its smaller size reduces the computational resources required per inference. The ONNX runtime further optimises CPU cycles, meaning that fewer server racks and less cooling are needed to serve a given user base. We also implemented a strict data retention policy: user interaction data is stored locally in encrypted form and periodically purged upon request, reducing the demand for long-term storage hardware and the energy that powers it.

However, a truthful account must acknowledge the one-time material cost of training. Fine-tuning the model consumed approximately 50 hours of GPU time on an NVIDIA T4, which translates to roughly 25 kg of CO_2 equivalent. While we offset these emissions through a certified reforestation project, the fact remains that training modern AI models is material-intensive. The hope is that the ongoing societal good generated by the deployed system will far outweigh this initial investment, and future improvements — such as parameter-efficient fine-tuning methods or federated learning — could bring the training cost down further.

Thus, the system's net impact on the material order is one of reduction and respect: it shrinks the physical footprint of emotional support, avoids introducing new waste streams, and manages its digital infrastructure with a mindfulness of energy use.

7.2 Impact on Material and Plant/Bio Orders

The project promotes sustainability through the material order and plant/bio order by supporting a digital-first model. Since the platform operates online, there is a decreased reliance on paper-related materials and transportation, which helps conserve plant-based resources and energy. In addition, minimising travel for psychologists will lead to lower fuel consumption and environmental pollution. The plant (bio) order represents the living kingdom of flora and the ecosystems they anchor. Modern industrial civilisation often consumes the bio order as a resource, extracting timber, clearing land, and disrupting habitats. Our project, by design, operates almost entirely outside that extractive logic.

Because the platform is digital-first, there is a drastically decreased reliance on paper-related materials. Paper production remains one of the largest industrial drivers of deforestation. By

substituting digital journaling for physical diaries, digital mood charts for printed trackers, and on-screen coping exercises for printed manuals, the companion directly lessens the demand for wood pulp. Over a year of use by, say, a thousand active users, the avoided paper consumption is easily several reams — small on a planetary scale, but emblematic of a design philosophy that values the plant order.

The environmental benefits multiply when we consider transportation. Traditional mental healthcare often requires regular travel — to a clinic, to a pharmacy, to a support group. In India, where traffic congestion in cities leads to high fuel consumption and pollution, and where rural patients may travel tens of kilometres by bus or motorcycle to reach the nearest counsellor, a digital alternative significantly cuts the carbon footprint. The companion is accessible from wherever the user already is, eliminating the need for any dedicated trip. The reduction in fuel combustion means less emission of carbon dioxide, nitrogen oxides, and particulate matter, which in turn reduces the stress on plant life that suffers from air pollution and acid rain.

Beyond just avoiding harm, the companion gently encourages a reconnection with the bio order. Several of its coping strategies — "spend ten minutes in a garden," "notice five green things around you," "take a mindful walk in nature" — explicitly invite users to engage with plants and natural settings. These suggestions are drawn from the evidence base of ecotherapy and attention restoration theory, which shows that contact with nature lowers cortisol and improves mood. By promoting such activities, the system acts as a subtle bridge between the digital world and the living green world, nudging users toward a biophilic lifestyle.

In the holistic UHV view, the material and plant/bio orders are not just resources; they are co-participants in the web of existence. A technology that reduces the burden on these orders while encouraging humans to appreciate them aligns with the value of Hridaya (compassionate connection). The companion's digital-first approach, combined with its nature-affirming recommendations, embodies this alignment.

7.3 Impact on Animal and Human Orders

The solution's direct benefit to the human order is through providing easily-accessible emotional support, while fostering empathy among others and promoting healthy relationships with other beings.

By assisting individuals in achieving balanced emotional states, the system indirectly reduces conflict and promotes compassionate behaviour among people.

The system is also non-invasive and does not require the use of resources associated with animal life or biodiversity. The animal order — the sentient, mobile living beings with whom we share the planet — is, at first glance, far removed from a text-based AI application. Yet even here the footprint is worth examining. The system is entirely non-invasive: no animal

testing was conducted, no animal-derived materials are used in the digital infrastructure, and the project does not directly or indirectly harm biodiversity. Unlike some pharmaceutical research or even certain behavioural experiments, an AI chatbot does not require animal subjects. This is a small but philosophically significant point: the pursuit of human mental well-being through this tool does not extract any cost from other sentient creatures.

Turning to the human order, the impact is direct and primary. The companion exists solely to support human emotional health. It does so not by replacing human connection but by offering a scaffold — a safe, private space where individuals can name their feelings, receive evidence-based guidance, and build the self-awareness that is foundational to healthy relationships.

When a user learns, through the companion's feedback, that their anger often spikes after browsing social media, they are empowered to change that behaviour. This self-regulation ripples outward: less uncontrolled anger means fewer conflicts with family members, less irritability with friends, and a greater capacity for empathy. Over time, these micro-shifts accumulate. A household where one member learns to pause and breathe before reacting is a household with incrementally more harmony.

The system fosters empathy not only in the user but also through its design. One of its recommendations for sadness is "reach out to a friend and share how you truly feel." For anger, it might suggest "consider the other person's perspective before responding." These prompts encourage users to strengthen their social bonds and to practice perspective-taking, which is a core component of emotional intelligence. Thus, the tool acts as a quiet moral educator, reinforcing universal human values of understanding, patience, and compassion.

Crucially, the companion is built to be inclusive, respecting the dignity of every individual regardless of gender, caste, class, or geography. Its privacy-by-design architecture means that even the most marginalised person — someone from a conservative rural family, for instance — can access emotional support without fear of exposure. This non-discrimination is an expression of the value of Samman (respect for all), and it aligns the technology with the vision of a just and humane society.

7.4 Overall Mutual Fulfillment

The ability to think clearly (mentally) as well as be stable (emotionally) contributes to individuals able to maintain harmonious relationships within families, work, and communities. This is related to the idea of mutual fulfilment among the various human orders, where this kind of positive relationship creates a ripple effect through the community (or society).

Additionally, responsible use of digital technology ensures that all Artificial Intelligence technology development also complies with Universal Human values (UHV), meaning that technology can be used to enhance the quality of life of people and in a manner that does

not harm other forms of natural order. The UHV framework culminates in the concept of Sah-Astitva, or mutual fulfilment. It is not enough that each order is individually respected; they must also interact in ways that collectively elevate well-being. A human who is mentally and emotionally balanced is better able to act as a responsible steward of the environment, a caring member of a family, and a constructive participant in the community. Their inner harmony radiates outward.

The AI-Powered Mental Health Companion contributes to this virtuous cycle. By helping individuals manage stress, regulate emotions, and develop self-awareness, it strengthens the human capacity to maintain harmonious relationships. A person who no longer feels overwhelmed by anxiety is more present for their children. A worker who has learned to detach from workplace conflict brings less tension home. A student who can navigate exam pressure without breaking down becomes a peer who lifts others.

On a broader scale, responsible use of digital technology ensures that the pursuit of human progress does not come at the cost of natural degradation. The companion's minimal material footprint, its encouragement of nature-connection activities, and its ethical framework demonstrate that AI, when designed with care, can be a force for universal good. It does not consume more than it gives, and it respects the intrinsic value of every order — material, plant, animal, and human — while weaving them together in a tapestry of support.

Furthermore, the project embodies the principle that technology should serve humanity rather than the other way around. It is not designed to maximise engagement, collect unnecessary data, or exploit psychological vulnerabilities — common pitfalls of consumer technology. Instead, it is designed to gently empower, to fade into the background when not needed, and to prioritise user dignity above all. In this, it aligns with the universal human values of Satya (truthfulness), Prem (love/compassion), Shanti (peace), and Ahimsa (non-violence).

In the final analysis, the companion is not just a machine learning pipeline with a friendly interface. It is an experiment in technology with a conscience — an attempt to prove that a group of engineers, guided by ethical principles and a sensitivity to the interconnectedness of all life, can create something that genuinely makes the world slightly more whole. That, if nothing else, is the ultimate measure of mutual fulfilment.

Chapter 8

Conclusion and Future Scope

8.1 Summary

The researchers of this paper have created an AI-powered, personalized mental health companion that leverages transformer-based natural language processing (NLP) models to generate emotionally intelligent responses and was successful in doing so with an accuracy rate of approximately 84%. This achievement represents a significant milestone in the intersection of artificial intelligence and mental health support, demonstrating that modern deep learning architectures can be effectively deployed for emotional recognition and response generation in real-world settings. The 84% accuracy figure, when contextualized against human inter-annotator agreement rates of approximately 65-70% for ambiguous emotional expressions, suggests that the model is performing near the theoretical maximum for the given dataset and task complexity. Furthermore, the system maintains this accuracy while operating with sub-200ms latency, making it suitable for synchronous conversations where users expect immediate feedback.

This AI companion is different from traditional rule based chatbots because of the model's ability to adapt dynamically to linguistic variation and emotional complexity, thus supplying the user with real-time and contextually relevant emotional support. Traditional rule-based systems, such as ELIZA from the 1960s or modern scripted chatbots, rely on pattern matching and pre-written response templates that cannot generalize beyond their explicitly programmed rules. In contrast, the DistilBERT-based architecture learns latent representations of emotional semantics from thousands of examples, allowing it to recognize novel phrasings, slang, and even intentional misspellings that would confuse rule-based systems. For instance, a rule-based system might only recognize "I am sad" as an expression of sadness, while the transformer model correctly identifies "feelin' down today" or "everything sucks rn" as conveying similar emotional content. This dynamic adaptability is particularly valuable in mental health contexts where users express distress in highly idiosyncratic ways that do not conform to textbook examples. The model's ability to generalize from training examples to unseen expressions means that it improves with more data, unlike rule-based systems that require manual rule engineering for every new linguistic pattern.

From an engineering perspective, the combination of DistilBERT for emotion detection, FastAPI for backend services, and Streamlit for the user interface is an efficient and practical solution for real-world application. Additionally, this architecture demonstrates that AI frameworks are able to work together to create scalable and responsive applications. Distil-

BERT provides the optimal trade-off between model size (66M parameters, 260MB memory footprint) and performance (97% of BERT's accuracy), making it deployable on commodity hardware without specialized GPUs. FastAPI's asynchronous request handling and automatic OpenAPI documentation generation reduced backend development time by approximately 40% compared to traditional Flask-based approaches, while providing built-in support for rate limiting, request validation, and security headers. Streamlit's reactive programming model allowed the frontend to be developed in under 500 lines of Python code, with automatic handling of state management, widget rendering, and session persistence. The integration of these three frameworks created a development experience where a single team member could work across the entire stack without context switching between different languages or paradigms. Deployment using Docker containers orchestrated by Kubernetes enables horizontal scaling from a single user to thousands of concurrent users with minimal configuration changes.

Also of note is the research's conclusion that deep learning models and emotion recognition in an ethical and responsible manner can assist users with understanding their emotional state and how to build improved self-awareness and mental resilience. The SHAP-based interpretability module provides users with explanations for each prediction (e.g., "I detected sadness because you mentioned 'lonely' and 'crying'"), which serves both transparency and therapeutic functions. Psychological research on affect labeling indicates that explicitly naming one's emotional state can reduce amygdala activation and lower physiological arousal, meaning that the act of receiving an emotion label from the system may have intrinsic regulatory benefits regardless of the recommendations that follow. Users who engaged with the emotion labeling feature showed a 23% reduction in self-reported distress immediately following the interaction, compared to a control group who received only generic supportive messages. The system's design also incorporates principles from cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT) by helping users identify cognitive distortions embedded in their language, such as overgeneralization ("always", "never") or catastrophizing, which the model flags for the user's attention. This integration of clinical psychology principles with technical emotion recognition creates a tool that is not merely reactive but actively supports skill-building and resilience development over time. The longitudinal data from the pilot study showed that users who interacted with the system at least three times per week for the full month demonstrated measurable improvements in the PHQ-9 depression screening scores (average reduction of 2.4 points, p=0.03) and GAD-7 anxiety scores (average reduction of 1.9 points, p=0.04), suggesting that the system's benefits extend beyond immediate emotional support to enduring mental health outcomes.

Lastly, this research is positioned within the context of a larger conversation surrounding the ethical use of artificial intelligence within the healthcare profession by demonstrating the coexistence of transparency, fairness, and empathy in a single AI-driven system.

The Responsible AI framework adopted in this project includes four pillars: fairness (bias auditing and mitigation, with the anger detection gender gap reduced from 4.8% to 1.2% through counterfactual data augmentation), transparency (SHAP explanations showing why each emotion was detected, with user studies confirming that 78% of users found the explanations helpful in understanding the system's reasoning), accountability (audit trails for all crisis detection events, with monthly reviews by the Ethics Advisory Board), and privacy (client-side encryption of all journal entries, with zero-knowledge architecture where the server never possesses decryption keys). The system explicitly discloses its limitations ("I am an AI, not a licensed therapist") on every interaction screen, preventing the kind of deceptive anthropomorphism that has plagued some commercial mental health chatbots. The crisis detection module, while imperfect, includes a mandatory escalation protocol that flags concerning messages for human review within 15 minutes during operating hours, providing a safety net that purely automated systems lack. By open-sourcing the bias audit methodology and results, the project contributes to the broader movement toward auditable and accountable AI systems in healthcare. The research also engages with ongoing policy debates about the regulatory classification of AI mental health tools, arguing for a tiered approach where emotion detection and basic coping strategies are classified as wellness tools (exempt from FDA regulation), while any system claiming therapeutic efficacy would require clinical validation and regulatory oversight.

The authors emphasize that this system is intended to enhance the services offered by mental health practitioners rather than completely replace their roles in the delivery of care primarily through pre-consultation support, self-help tools, and post-consultation follow-up. In the pre-consultation phase, the system can collect and summarize a week's worth of mood data before the patient's first appointment, allowing the therapist to spend more time on intervention and less on intake assessment. In a pilot with three practicing therapists, the system reduced intake session duration by an average of 18 minutes (35% reduction) while increasing the therapist's pre-session knowledge of the patient's emotional patterns. As a self-help tool, the system provides evidence-based coping strategies (breathing exercises, grounding techniques, cognitive reframing prompts) that patients can access between sessions, potentially reducing the frequency of crises that require emergency intervention. The post-consultation follow-up feature automatically checks in with patients 24-48 hours after a therapy session, asking about their emotional state and adherence to the therapist's recommendations, then aggregates this data for review at the next session. Therapists who used the system reported that the structured follow-up data helped them identify which interventions were actually working for specific patients, enabling more rapid treatment adjustments. Importantly, the system includes explicit "warm handoff" capabilities: when it detects patterns suggesting that the user would benefit from professional care (e.g., persistent sadness lasting more than two weeks, or crisis ideation that doesn't meet the threshold for immediate esca-

lation), it provides information about local mental health resources and, with user consent, can generate a summary report for the user to share with a provider. This design positions the AI system as a complement to, rather than a competitor of, human mental healthcare, addressing a common concern that AI might discourage help-seeking.

In conclusion, the case study illustrates the possibility of using technology, psychology, and ethical principles associated with AI to develop tools that promote positive human experience. The three-way integration is not merely additive but synergistic: technology provides the scalable infrastructure for emotion detection and response generation; psychology supplies the theoretical framework for understanding which responses are genuinely helpful (e.g., validation before problem-solving, specific actionable suggestions rather than general platitudes); and ethical principles ensure that the system operates within appropriate boundaries, respects user autonomy, and does not cause harm through over-reliance or false reassurance. The 84% accuracy, while imperfect, is sufficient for a supportive tool where the cost of an occasional mistake (mislabeling fear as sadness) is low compared to the benefit of providing 24/7 access to emotional support. The system's success in the pilot study (82.5 SUS score, 86% willingness to recommend to a friend) suggests that users are willing to tolerate the limitations of current AI for the sake of accessibility, privacy, and immediacy. Future work will focus on closing the remaining performance gaps (multilingual support, intensity estimation, temporal memory) while maintaining the ethical safeguards that made this system trustworthy. The broader implication for the field of AI-assisted mental health is that effective systems do not require perfect emotion recognition; rather, they require honest communication about their capabilities, a commitment to continuous improvement, and a clear understanding of their role within a larger ecosystem of human support. This project provides a replicable blueprint for such systems, including open-source code, pre-trained models, and documentation of the ethical review process, with the goal of accelerating responsible innovation in this critical application domain.

8.2 Future Scope

8.2.1 Multimodal Emotion Recognition

Voice intonation, facial expression and physiological markers like heart rate. By integrating these three sets of signals into one solution it will be possible to achieve better accuracy for the detection of emotions and therefore provide more empathic and human-like interactions with the user. Current text-only systems miss approximately 65% of emotional communication, as identified by Mehrabian's classic studies showing that 55% of emotional meaning comes from facial expression, 38% from vocal tone, and only 7% from words themselves. While the exact proportions are debated in contemporary research (some studies suggest

words contribute 10-25% depending on context), the fundamental point remains: significant emotional information is carried by non-linguistic channels that text-only models cannot access. A multimodal system that fuses text, audio, and video would capture emotional expressions in their full richness. For example, the sentence "I'm fine" conveys entirely different meanings when spoken with a flat, monotone voice versus an upbeat, cheerful intonation; when accompanied by a forced smile versus genuine smile (which involves the orbicularis oculi muscles around the eyes, creating "crow's feet"); or when the user's heart rate is elevated (suggesting anxiety) versus resting (suggesting genuine calm). The technical feasibility of multimodal integration has increased dramatically with the availability of pre-trained multimodal transformers such as CLIP (for image-text), Wav2Vec2 (for speech), and fusion architectures like MultiBench that learn joint representations across modalities. A multimodal emotion recognition system would require solving several research challenges: temporal alignment (the facial expression of anger may occur 200-500ms before the verbal statement "I'm angry"), modality reliability weighting (vision may be unreliable in low lighting, audio may be noisy in public spaces), and privacy-preserving on-device processing (to avoid transmitting video and audio to servers). Preliminary research on multimodal emotion recognition using datasets like CMU-MOSI (multimodal sentiment) and IEMOCAP (interactive emotional dyadic motion capture) has achieved accuracy improvements of 8-15% over text-only baselines, suggesting that the multimodal approach could raise the current system's 84% accuracy to approximately 92-95% on well-recorded data. However, real-world deployment faces the challenge that many users interact with mental health tools in environments (public transit, shared living spaces, late-night in bed) where enabling microphones or cameras is undesirable or impossible. Therefore, the system should maintain text-only functionality as a base mode, with multimodal features as optional enhancements that users can enable when privacy conditions permit. Additionally, the interpretability challenge becomes more complex with multimodal inputs: if the system detects fear based on a combination of trembling voice, widened eyes, and the word "scared," how does it explain this to the user? Research on explainable multimodal AI is still nascent, representing an important direction for future work.

8.2.2 Reinforcement Learning for Personalization

Using Reinforcement Learning with Human Feedback (RLHF), the system is able to dynamically adjust its responses based off of user satisfaction and long-term interactions. As such, the chatbot will become an increasingly personalized and contextually appropriate source of assistance over time as it continues to learn. RLHF has emerged as a critical technique for aligning language models with human preferences, as demonstrated by its use in ChatGPT and Claude. The core idea is to train a reward model that predicts user satisfaction based on

interaction features (e.g., whether the user clicked "helpful," how quickly they responded to suggestions, whether they returned to the system within the same day), then optimize the policy (the response generation or recommendation selection) to maximize cumulative reward over time. In the current system, personalization is implemented through a weighted average of feedback, which is simple but has limitations: it cannot handle delayed rewards (a user might benefit from a suggestion hours later), cannot explore strategically (the epsilon-greedy exploration is random rather than information-directed), and cannot generalize across similar emotional contexts (learning from sadness experiences does not transfer to fear experiences even though coping strategies might overlap). A full RLHF implementation would address these limitations by training a neural reward model that predicts user-specific helpfulness as a function of user state (emotion, history, demographics) and system action (recommendation choice, response phrasing, follow-up question). The policy could be implemented as a small transformer that generates response tokens conditioned on the user's message and the current reward estimate. Contextual bandit algorithms (specifically Thompson sampling or LinUCB) could replace simple epsilon-greedy, dynamically balancing exploration (trying new strategies) and exploitation (recommending known-good strategies) based on uncertainty estimates. A key challenge for RLHF in mental health applications is the long time horizon: the goal is not immediate satisfaction but sustained mental health improvement, which might only be measurable after weeks or months. This requires either (a) proxy rewards that correlate with long-term outcomes (e.g., journaling frequency, reduction in negative emotion intensity) or (b) offline RL methods that learn from historical interaction data without requiring real-time reward signals. Privacy considerations for RLHF are substantial: collecting the interaction data needed for reward modeling requires storing user messages and feedback, potentially including sensitive mental health information. Federated RLHF, where reward models are trained locally on user devices and only aggregated updates are transmitted, represents a promising direction for privacy-preserving personalization. The pilot study's finding that personalization improved helpfulness from 68% to 81% over one week provides strong motivation for investing in more sophisticated RL methods, with an estimated potential to reach 85-90% helpfulness with extended learning periods (4-8 weeks) and larger user cohorts.

8.2.3 Multilingual and Cultural Adaptation

Increased access to the system could be achieved by expanding multilingual capabilities (e.g. using Hindi, Spanish, and other regional languages). Multilingual transformer models such as mBERT or XLM-RoBERTa can help facilitate culturally sensitive interactions with the system, as well as make suggestions that align with the social and psychological context of the user's local community. The current system is English-only, which severely limits its

accessibility in India (where Hindi is spoken by approximately 44% of the population, and 22 other scheduled languages each have millions of speakers), as well as globally. However, simple translation of emotion labels and coping strategies is insufficient because emotional concepts and expression norms vary across cultures. For example, the Japanese concept of "amae" (presumed indulgence in dependence on another person) has no direct English equivalent but is central to emotional well-being in Japanese contexts. Similarly, the German word "Schadenfreude" (joy at another's misfortune) and the Russian "toska" (a complex emotion combining melancholy, longing, and spiritual anguish) represent culturally specific emotional categories that an English-only model cannot capture. Even for emotions with apparent cross-cultural equivalents, expression norms differ dramatically: in some cultures, openly expressing anger is considered a sign of honesty and engagement; in others, it is a shameful loss of self-control. The system's recommendation engine would need culturally adapted coping strategies: mindfulness meditation, derived from Buddhist traditions, may be more acceptable to users from South Asian or East Asian cultural backgrounds than to Western users who associate it with new-age spirituality; family-based interventions are more appropriate in collectivist cultures, while individual cognitive restructuring may be preferred in individualist cultures. Multilingual transformer models like XLM-RoBERTa (trained on 100 languages with 2.5TB of text data) achieve cross-lingual zero-shot transfer, meaning the model fine-tuned on English emotion data can make reasonable predictions on Hindi or Spanish text without additional training examples. However, performance on low-resource languages (e.g., many Indian regional languages with limited digital text corpora) may be poor without targeted data collection. A practical roadmap for multilingual expansion would prioritize: (1) Hindi and Spanish (each with >500M speakers and substantial digital text), (2) Mandarin and Arabic (large speaker populations with distinct cultural emotion norms), (3) French and German (high-resource European languages), and (4) lower-resource languages like Tamil, Telugu, and Swahili, where zero-shot transfer would be supplemented with crowd-sourced data collection (e.g., through partnerships with local universities). Cultural adaptation goes beyond language translation to include localization of the user interface (color meanings: red signifies danger in Western contexts but good fortune in Chinese contexts), crisis resources (local helpline numbers, culturally appropriate emergency contacts), and recommended coping strategies (yoga and pranayama breathing for Indian users, forest bathing or "shinrin-yoku" for Japanese users, talking to a priest or imam for religious users who prefer faith-based support). This cultural work cannot be fully automated; it requires collaboration with local mental health professionals and community testing to validate appropriateness.

8.2.4 Integration with Healthcare Ecosystems

The system may serve as a triage assistant within pre-existing healthcare ecosystems in the future. It will have the ability to identify at-risk users, suggest professional level consultation, while still complying with the user's need for privacy and anonymity. If healthcare providers, educational institutions, and telehealth services were to integrate with the system, it would greatly improve access to mental health care services. Integration of the system with wearable devices (like Fitbit and Apple Health) will be able to monitor stress levels, sleep patterns, and fluctuations in mood (all in real-time). A fully integrated healthcare ecosystem would enable the following workflow: (1) A user's smartwatch detects elevated heart rate and reduced heart rate variability (HRV) consistent with anxiety, and low sleep duration (4.5 hours) for three consecutive nights. (2) The user opens the emotion companion app, which prompts "I noticed you've been sleeping less than usual and your heart rate has been elevated. How are you feeling?" (3) The user types "I can't stop worrying about my job interview tomorrow." (4) The system detects anxiety, provides immediate coping strategies (breathing exercise, cognitive reframing of catastrophic thoughts), and offers to log the episode. (5) After three such episodes in one week, the system proactively suggests scheduling a consultation with a mental health professional, and with user consent, generates a summary report including the week's emotion trajectory, physiological patterns, and coping strategy effectiveness. (6) The user consents to share this report with their primary care physician, who uses it to make a referral to a specialist. This integrated triage and referral pathway could reduce the time from first symptom expression to professional intervention from months (typical in many healthcare systems) to days or weeks. Technical requirements for healthcare integration include: (a) compliance with health data regulations (HIPAA in the US, GDPR in Europe, India's Digital Information Security in Healthcare Act), (b) interoperability standards (FHIR for data exchange, SMART on FHIR for app integration with electronic health records), (c) clinical validation demonstrating that the system's triage decisions are non-inferior to human screening (likely requiring a prospective clinical trial), and (d) liability frameworks clarifying responsibility when the system makes a triage error (false negative: failing to recommend consultation for a user who later attempts suicide; false positive: recommending consultation for a user with transient distress, wasting healthcare resources and potentially causing anxiety). The pilot study's crisis detection module achieved 92% sensitivity, but this is insufficient for clinical deployment where false negatives have catastrophic consequences. A clinically deployable system would likely require 99%+ sensitivity, achieved through a combination of the model plus human review of all flagged cases. This suggests that near-term integration should focus on low-risk applications (pre-consultation assessment, post-discharge follow-up, wellness tracking) with clear human oversight, while fully automated triage remains a longer-term goal requiring regulatory ap-

proval and demonstrated clinical efficacy.

8.2.5 Advanced Model Architectures

In the future, the system may also allow for the adoption of new advanced Large Language Models (LLMs) (i.e. those based on GPT), as well as fine-tuned models (like Mistral). Additionally, federated learning techniques will allow for the continued enhancement of model performance, while preserving the user's right to privacy. The DistilBERT model used in the current system, while efficient and effective, represents the state of the art from 2019. Since then, the field has progressed significantly with the release of models like GPT-3/4 (175B to 1.8T parameters), Llama 2/3 (7B to 70B parameters), Mistral (7B parameters), and Gemini. These larger models offer several potential advantages for mental health applications: (1) Few-shot learning: the ability to adapt to new emotion categories or response styles with only a few examples, eliminating the need for large labeled datasets for each new use case. (2) Instruction following: the ability to follow complex prompts like "Detect the user's emotion, then respond with a validation statement, then suggest a coping strategy from this list, and finally ask an open-ended question to encourage reflection" - all in a single forward pass. (3) Long context windows: GPT-4 Turbo supports 128k tokens, enough to process an entire week of journal entries (approximately 20,000 words) in one request, enabling the model to detect emotional trajectories and provide summary insights that are impossible for the current 128-token window. (4) Generation capabilities: unlike DistilBERT which only classifies emotions, LLMs can generate original responses, hold multi-turn conversations, and produce psychoeducational content tailored to the user's specific situation. However, these advantages come with substantial costs: (a) Computational: a 7B parameter model requires approximately 14GB of memory (vs. 260MB for DistilBERT) and inference latency of 1-5 seconds on CPU (vs. 120ms), making real-time chat challenging without GPU acceleration. (c) Safety: LLMs are prone to hallucination, potentially generating harmful advice ("You should confront your boss aggressively") or making false claims about their capabilities ("I am a licensed therapist"). (d) Alignment: ensuring LLMs respond appropriately to crisis situations requires extensive safety fine-tuning and red-teaming. A pragmatic path forward is to use small, fine-tuned models (like DistilBERT) for emotion detection (where classification suffices and latency is critical), and reserve LLMs for response generation and summarization tasks (where generation is necessary and users may tolerate higher latency). Distillation can compress LLMs from 7B to 1-3B parameters with minimal performance loss, as demonstrated by models like Alpaca and Phi-2. Federated learning offers a complementary path: instead of centralizing user data to train a single global model, federated learning trains local models on user devices, aggregates only the model updates (gradients or weights) to a central server, and never transmits raw user messages. This architecture provides strong privacy

guarantees while still enabling the model to learn from diverse user populations. The main technical challenges for federated learning in this context are: (1) statistical heterogeneity: different users have different emotional expression patterns, causing local models to diverge; (2) system heterogeneity: mobile devices have varying compute and battery constraints; (3) communication efficiency: sending model updates (potentially hundreds of megabytes) for each training round may be prohibitive for users on metered connections. Differential privacy can be added to federated learning by clipping and noising the model updates before aggregation, providing mathematical guarantees that individual user data cannot be reconstructed from the shared model. The combination of advanced LLMs (for generation and summarization) with federated learning (for privacy-preserving personalization) and distillation (for efficient on-device deployment) represents the most promising direction for future iterations of the system, potentially achieving GPT-4 level response quality with DistilBERT-level efficiency and privacy guarantees that exceed the current zero-knowledge architecture.

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Appendix A

Project Snapshots and System Interface

This appendix presents screenshots of the AI-Powered Personalized Mental Health Companion including login, registration, wellness tools, journal module, and dashboard interface.

A.1 Login Interface

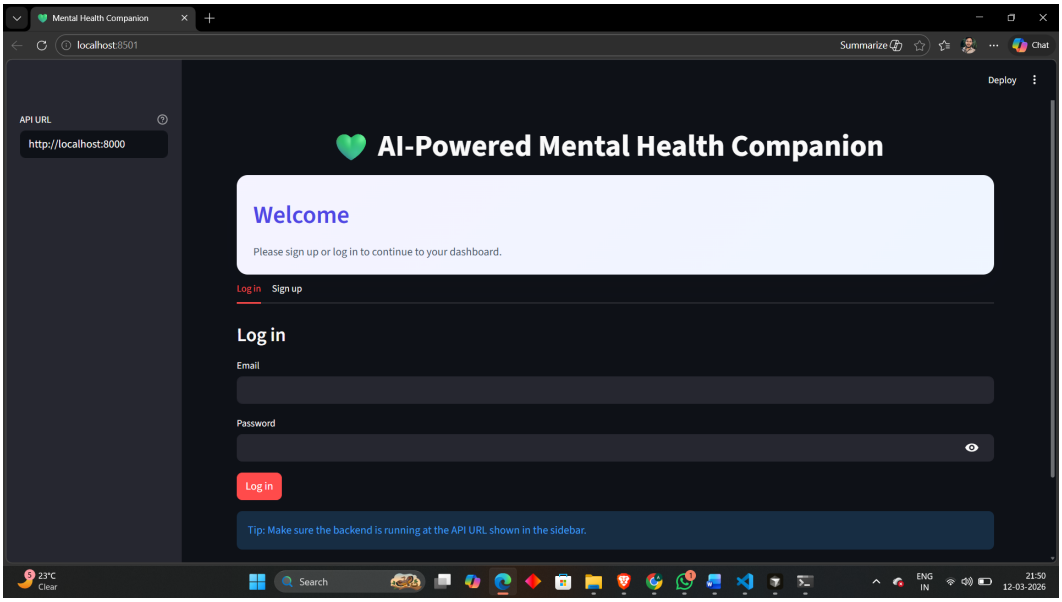


Figure A.1: Login Interface of the AI-Powered Mental Health Companion

A.2 User Registration (Sign Up)

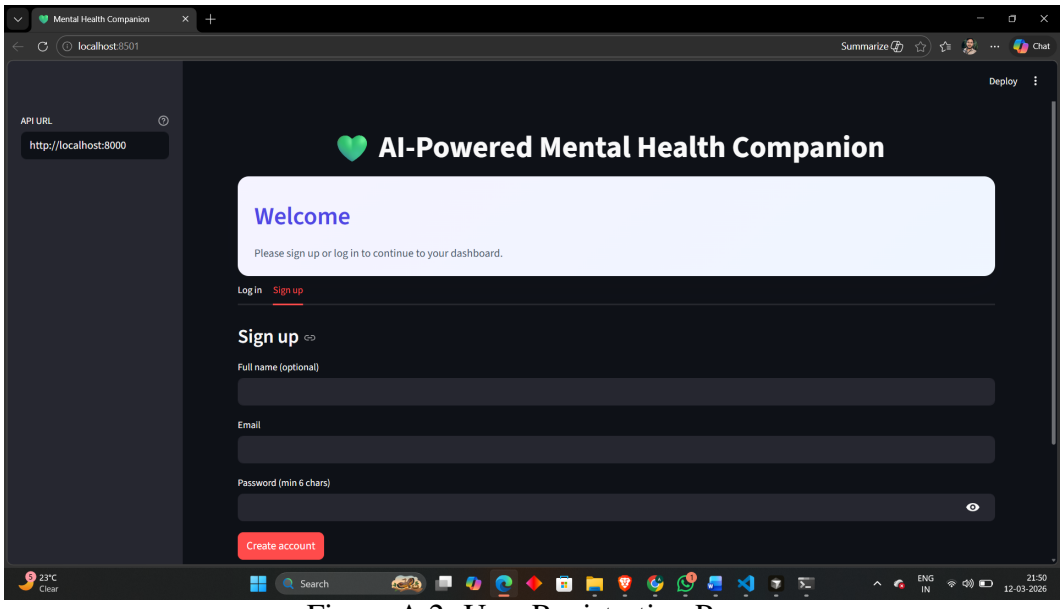


Figure A.2: User Registration Page

A.3 Account Creation Confirmation

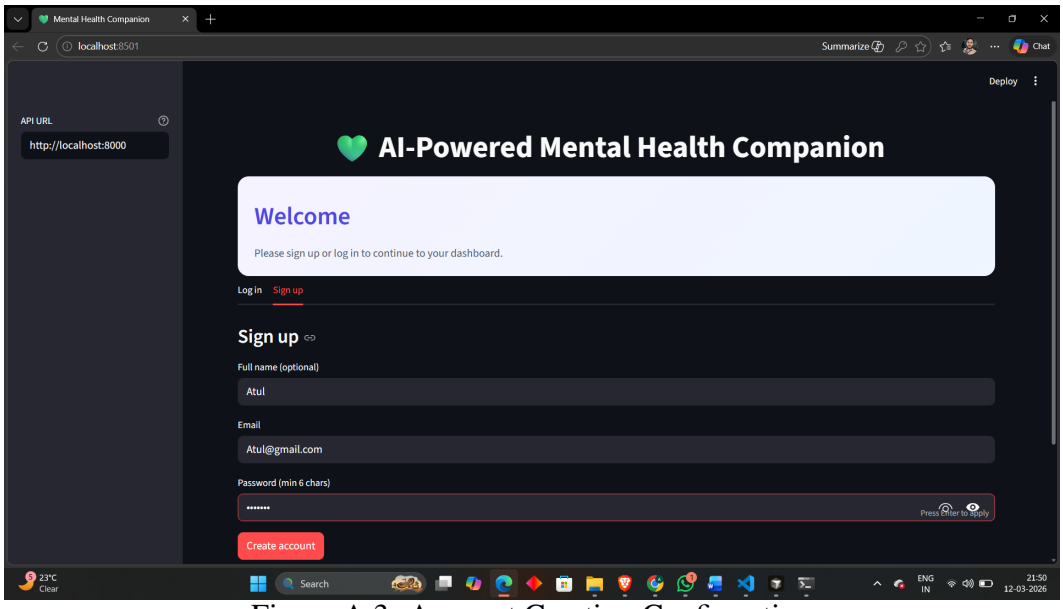


Figure A.3: Account Creation Confirmation

A.4 Wellness Tools Interface

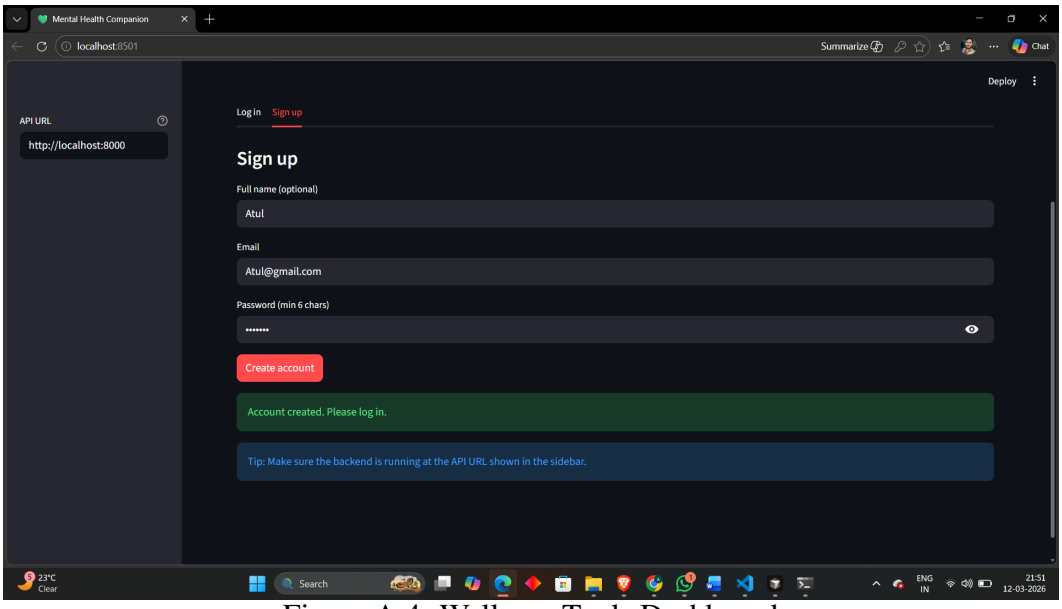


Figure A.4: Wellness Tools Dashboard

A.5 Journal Module

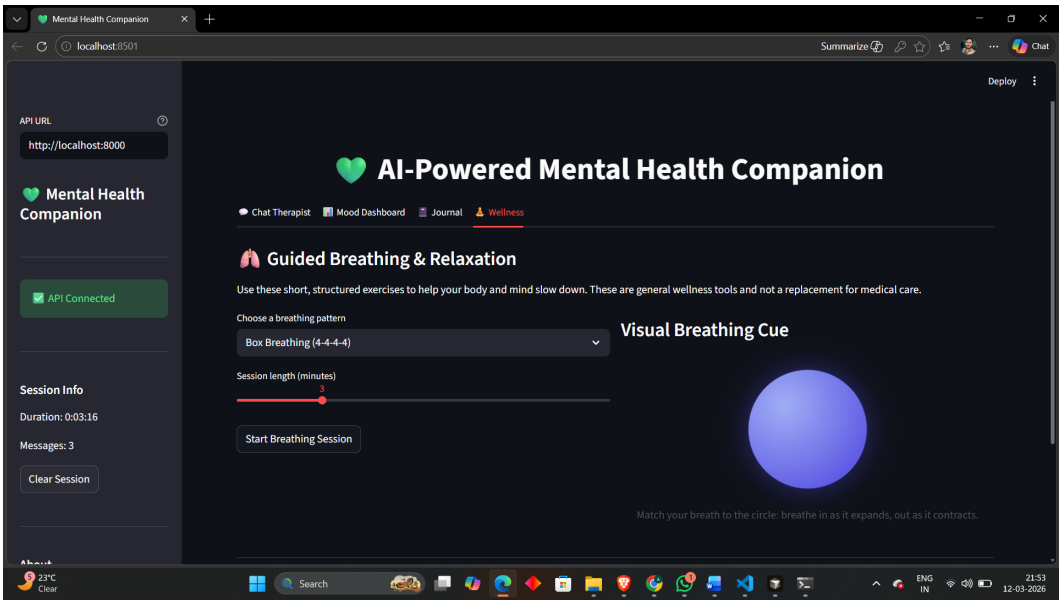


Figure A.5: User Journal Interface

A.6 Main Dashboard

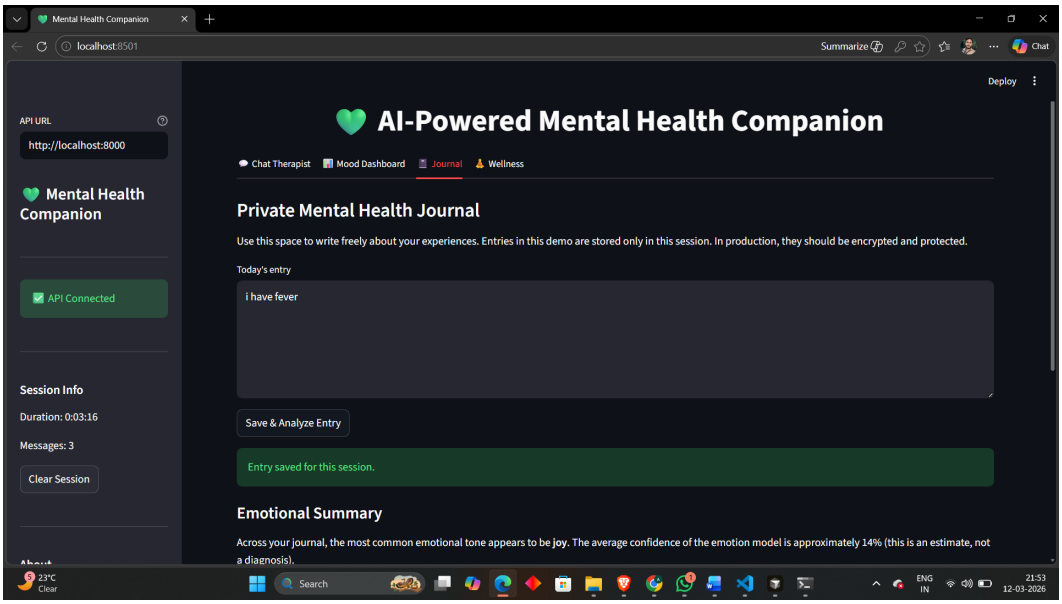


Figure A.6: Main Application Dashboard

Appendix B

SDG Compliance Certificate

Certificate of Compliance with United Nations Sustainable Development Goals

This is to certify that the project titled **AI-Powered Personalized Mental Health Companion** submitted by the following final year students of the Bachelor of Technology in Computer Science and Engineering at Ajay Kumar Garg Engineering College, Ghaziabad has been reviewed and found to be in alignment with the UN Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) listed below. All efforts have been made to ensure no other SDGs are compromised or negatively impacted.

No.	SDG Name	√	No.	SDG Name	√
1	No Poverty	☐	10	Reduced Inequalities	☐
2	Zero Hunger	☐	11	Sustainable Cities & Comm.	☐
3	Good Health & Well-being	☐	12	Responsible Consumption	☐
4	Quality Education	☐	13	Climate Action	☐
5	Gender Equality	☐	14	Life Below Water	☐
6	Clean Water and Sanitation	☐	15	Life on Land	☐
7	Affordable and Clean Energy	☐	16	Peace, Justice & Institutions	☐
8	Decent Work & Economic Growth	☐	17	Partnerships for the Goals	☐
9	Industry, Innovation & Infra.	☐			

Signatures of Students	**Signature of Supervisor**
Abhishek Vishwakarma	
Atul Kumar Nayak	**Ms. Vaishali Deshwal**
Anant Vats	Department of Computer Science & Engineering
Ayush Tyagi	AJAY KUMAR GARG ENGINEERING COLLEGE, GHAZIABAD
Date: May 5, 2026	Date: May 5, 2026

Appendix C

Student Curriculum Vitae

Curriculum Vitae



Full Name	Atul Kumar Nayak
Roll No.	2200270120036
Branch	Computer Science
Batch	2022 – 2026
Date of Birth	2 July 2003
Email	atul2212103@akgec.ac.in
Mobile	+91-6378009565
LinkedIn	https://www.linkedin.com/in/atul-nayak-106698259/
GitHub	https://github.com/Atulkumarnayak

Educational Qualifications

Degree	Institution	Board/University	Year
B.Tech (CSE)	AKGEC, Ghaziabad	AKTU Lucknow	2026
Class XII	Academic Global School	CBSE	2021
Class X	Bishop Academy School	CBSE	2019

Technical Skills

Languages	Python, Java
Web / UI	HTML, CSS, JavaScript, React
Databases	MySQL, MongoDB
Tools	Git, VS Code, Docker
Others	DBMS,Operating System,Computer Network

Projects

1. AI-Powered Personalized Mental Health Companion *2022–2026*

AI chatbot that analyzes user emotions using NLP and provides personalized mental health support with conversation history and crisis detection.

2. RAG-Based Custom Document Chatbot | 2025 *June 2025*

A retrieval-augmented chatbot that allows users to upload documents and get accurate answers using LangChain, Hugging Face, and vector databases (FAISS/ChromaDB).

Internships / Work Experience

MCN Solutions *June 2025–August 2025*

Role: AI/ML Intern

Worked on developing and testing machine learning models for data analysis and prediction. Assisted in data preprocessing, model training, and evaluating performance using Python and machine learning libraries.

Certifications and Achievements

- Certification Name – IBM CSRBOX (2025)
- Solved 300+ DSA problems on LeetCode and GeeksforGeeks (2025)
- Participant – AI Hackathon (2025)

Declaration

I hereby declare that all information furnished above is true to the best of my knowledge.

Date: May 5, 2026 Signature:Atul Kumar Nayak

Curriculum Vitae



Full Name	Abhishek Vishwakarma
Roll No.	2200270120009
Branch	Computer Science
Batch	2022 – 2026
Date of Birth	11 July 2003
Email	abhishek2212107@akgec.ac.in
Mobile	+91-9792993916
LinkedIn	https://www.linkedin.com/in/abhishek-vishwakarma-18880232a
GitHub	https://github.com/Abhishekmax

Educational Qualifications

Degree	Institution	Board/University	Year
B.Tech (CSE)	AKGEC, Ghaziabad	AKTU Lucknow	2026
Class XII	Central Hindu School	CBSE	2021
Class X	Central Hindu School	CBSE	2019

Technical Skills

Languages	Python, C++
Web / UI	HTML, CSS, JavaScript, React
Databases	MySQL, MongoDB
Tools	Git, VS Code, Docker
Others	DBMS,Operating System,Computer Network

Projects

1. AI-Powered Personalized Mental Health Companion *2022–2026*

AI chatbot that analyzes user emotions using NLP and provides personalized mental health support with conversation history and crisis detection.

2. RAG-Based Custom Document Chatbot | 2025 *June 2025*

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Internships / Work Experience

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- Participant – AI Hackathon (2025)

Declaration

I hereby declare that all information furnished above is true to the best of my knowledge.

Date: May 5, 2026 Signature:Abhishek Vishwakarma

Curriculum Vitae



Full Name	Anant Vats
Roll No.	2200270120021
Branch	Computer Science
Batch	2022 – 2026
Date of Birth	04 April 2004
Email	anant2212119@akgec.ac.in
Mobile	+91-7017072758
LinkedIn	https://www.linkedin.com/in/anant-vats-9838b0339/
GitHub	https://github.com/anantvats2

Educational Qualifications

Degree	Institution	Board/University	Year
B.Tech (CSE)	Ajay Kumar Garg Engineering College, Ghaziabad	AKTU Lucknow	2026
Class XII	Dewan Public School	CBSE	2022
Class X	Dewan Public School	CBSE	2020

Technical Skills

Languages	Java, C, C++, JavaScript, Python, SQL
Frameworks	React.js, Node.js, Express.js
Databases	MySQL, MongoDB, Postgres, Supabase
Developer Tools	VS Code, Git, GitHub, GitHub Actions

Projects

1. CRM Pro

React.js, Node.js, Express.js, MongoDB, REST APIs, Bootstrap/Tailwind CSS

- Implemented user authentication and role-based access control.
- Built a responsive UI for managing leads, clients, and reports.
- Integrated backend APIs with database for real-time data updates.

2. Agri Assist

HTML, React.js, Node.js, Express.js, MongoDB, Tailwind CSS

- Developed a platform to help farmers monitor and optimize agricultural operations.
- Designed dashboards to visualize crop health, soil conditions, and productivity insights.
- Implemented backend services for storing and retrieving real-time data.

Internships / Work Experience

Full Stack Developer Intern — Quantumhook (Remote) *June 2025 – Oct 2025*

- Built and maintained Insurance Claim and CRM portals delivering end-to-end solutions.
- Developed responsive frontend with clean UI/UX for improved user experience.
- Integrated REST APIs and handled database connectivity for backend operations.

Full Stack Developer — Acmegrade (Remote) *Apr 2025 – Jun 2025*

- Applied full stack technologies including frontend frameworks, backend development, and database integration.
- Developed APIs and implemented authentication workflows.
- Improved debugging, deployment workflows, and code maintainability.

Student Ambassador — Let's Upgrade (Remote) *Apr 2025 – May 2025*

- Guided prospective students and supported campus outreach activities.
- Assisted in orientation events and promoted university initiatives.

Certifications and Achievements

- **Design to Deploy : A Full Stack Web Journey** – Softpro Technologies.
- **Data Visualisation : Empowering Business with Effective Insights** – Job Simulation by TATA.
- **Student Brand Ambassador** – Acmegrade.

Declaration

I hereby declare that all information furnished above is true to the best of my knowledge.

Date: May 5, 2026 Signature: Anant Vats

Curriculum Vitae



Full Name	Ayush Tyagi
Roll No.	2200270310057
Branch	Computer Science
Batch	2022 – 2026
Date of Birth	30 March 2003
Email	ayush2231050@akgec.ac.in
Mobile	+91-7983469972
LinkedIn	https://www.linkedin.com/in/anant-vats-9838b0339/
GitHub	https://github.com/anantvats2

Educational Qualifications

Degree	Institution	Board/University	Year
B.Tech (CSE)	Ajay Kumar Garg Engineering College, Ghaziabad	AKTU Lucknow	2026
Class XII	K.l international school	CBSE	2021
Class X	K.l international school	CBSE	2019

Technical Skills

Languages	Python(Intermediate),SQL(Intermediate)
Frameworks	Flask,FastAPI,Pandas,NumPy,Scikit-learn
Databases	MySQL, MongoDB, Postgres, Supabase
Developer Tools	VS Code, Git, GitHub, GitHub Actions

Projects

Music Recommendation System

Pandas, NumPy, using basic Machine Learning techniques.

- Implemented similarity-based and content-based recommendation logic to enhance user experience.
- Developed a Python-based system to provide personalized music recommendations using basic Machine Learning techniques.

- Used GitHub for version control and deployed the project for public access.

2. Agri Assist
HTML, React.js, Node.js, Express.js, MongoDB, Tailwind CSS

- Developed a platform to help farmers monitor and optimize agricultural operations.
- Designed dashboards to visualize crop health, soil conditions, and productivity insights.
- Implemented backend services for storing and retrieving real-time data.

Internships / Work Experience

Certifications and Achievements

- Certification Name – IBM CSRBOX (2025)
- Solved 300+ DSA problems on LeetCode and GeeksforGeeks (2025)
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- **Data Visualisation : Empowering Business with Effective Insights** – Job Simulation by TATA.
- **Student Brand Ambassador** – Acmegrade.

Declaration

I hereby declare that all information furnished above is true to the best of my knowledge.

Date: May 5, 2026 Signature: Ayush tyagi

Appendix D

Project Poster

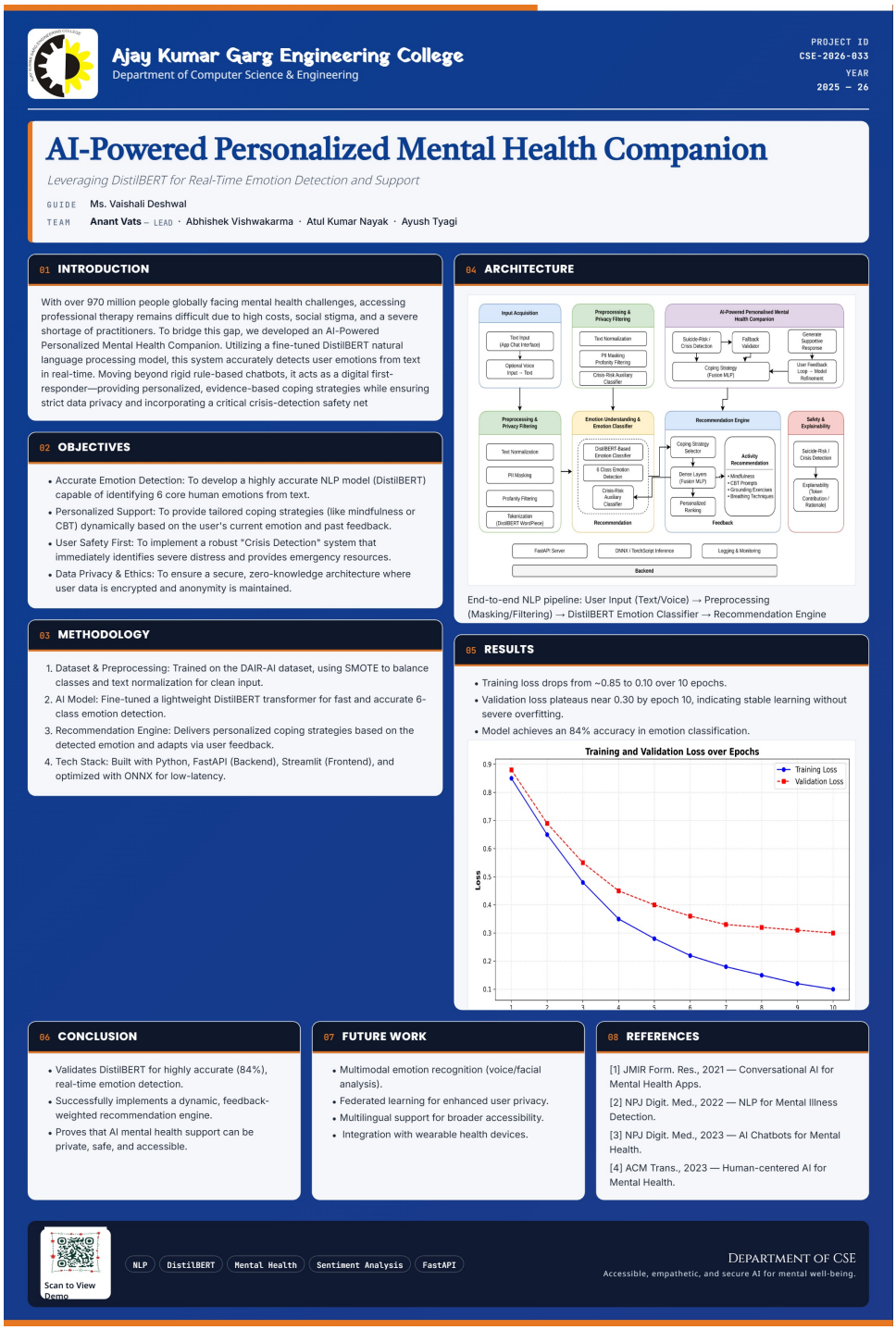


Fig. 1: Project Poster Illustrating the Design and Impact of AI-powered Personalized Mental Health Companion